

	सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India
1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911	
BRANCH OFFICE: BP-56, SHALIMAR BAGH, NEW DELHI-110088	
POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property) [Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]	
Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Shalimar Bagh Branch, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) and 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 30.03.2026, Calling upon the Borrower: SRI PRASHANT S/O SRI RAKESH KUMAR YADAV & SRI RAKESH KUMAR YADAV, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs.10,25,824.44 (Rupees Ten Lakh Twenty Five Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty Four and Paise Forty Four Only) (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 30.03.2026), plus interest and other charges from 30.03.2026 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower having failed to pay the entire dues of the Bank, notice is hereby given to the borrower, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this 01st Day of July 2026. The borrower and the Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Central Bank of India, Shalimar Bagh Branch, New Delhi for Rs.10,25,824.44 (Rupees Ten Lakh Twenty Five Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty Four and Paise Forty Four Only) (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 30.03.2026), plus interest and other charges from 30.03.2026. The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section (13) of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.	
DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY	
Property No.RZ-G-30, Old Plot No.5, Flat No.C-4, 3rd Floor, Part of Khasra No.55/18 and 55/19, area 65 Sq. Yards situated in Vill. Palam, Raj Nagar, Part-II, Palam Colony, Delhi-110077. Bounded By: North: Gali 10 Feet East: Plot No.1 South: Road 15 Feet West: Plot No.6	
PLACE: NEW DELHI DATE: 01/07/2026 (Authorised Officer), Central Bank of India	

Govt completes over 90% drain desilting work across city

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has completed more than 90 per cent of drain-desilting work across the city to reduce waterlogging problems during monsoon. The Public Works Department (PWD), which is the biggest drain-owning agency in the national capital, has cleared more than 90 per cent of its drain-desilting work across its three main zones.

According to official figures, till July 2, 539.34 km in PWD's East Zone, 603 km in the South Zone and 812 km in the North Zone, ie, around 1955 km of drains of the total

2123 km drainage network has been desilted.

The PWD is responsible for the management of 2123 km of drainage network across the city, which is around 50 per cent of the total drainage network of the city.

"Our priority is to clean the drainage network and make it functional to ensure that even during heavy rainfall, water does not accumulate and disrupt movement. For this, we have strengthened the manpower and the desilting work is ongoing at the desired pace with overall more than 90 per cent of the work completed," Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said.

The Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) Department has also completed 93 per cent of the desilting work across 77 drains, with more than 31 lakh metric tonnes (MT) of silt already removed. The department currently manages 382 kilometres of drain length, including the Najafgarh drain, Barapullah drain and Delhi Gate drain.

"Officials have also been directed to ensure proper disposal of the silt and prevent it from flowing back into the drains," Singh added.

The Delhi government had identified 169 locations across the city that are prone to waterlogging. Officials said that a total of 445 waterlog-



ging hotspots have been mapped based on the traffic police data from 2023, 2024 and 2025, and are currently under close monitoring.

Of these, 31 spots are located along the Ring Road

only, according to the Delhi government's flood control order published recently. To manage any problems in these spots and others areas, the PWD and the I&FC have made arrangements for tem-

porary pumps, quick response teams and automatic pumping stations.

"Till June 25, the MCD removed 1.7 lakh MT of silt from its 793 major stormwater drains measuring four feet and above, achieving 125.88 per cent of its phase 1 target of 1.4 lakh MT," an MCD official said. The MCD also exceeded its target for smaller drains. It desilted 29,686.83 MT of silt from 12,892 drains, against the Phase-I target of 25,850.5 MT, achieving 114.84 per cent of the target.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has successfully achieved 100 per cent desilting of bell-mouths and

gully traps (GT) across its jurisdiction during the second round of its cleanliness drive, NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal said.

"As of July 1, 2026, all 7,888 identified bell-mouths and 4,833 gully traps were thoroughly inspected and cleaned, leaving zero backlog ahead of the monsoon spells. Additionally, the civic body has recorded a 99.12 per cent completion rate for its rainwater harvesting systems, having serviced 337 out of 340 total units," Chahal said.

Highlighting the scale of the pre-monsoon preparedness carried out between January and June 2026, Chahal said that a total of 885

cubic meters of silt was extracted from bell-mouths, gully traps, and manholes to ensure smooth drainage and prevent waterlogging in the New Delhi area.

For timely updates and monitoring, the government has also set up 16 flood control posts, including nine along the Yamuna river, four on Najafgarh drain, two along the supplementary drain and one near Jahangirpuri drain. The department has also constructed eight embankments along the Yamuna. The Flood Control Department has also made provisions for assistance of the Army in controlling flooding and other related activities.

Govt unveils ₹8,300 cr plan to combat pollution

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Friday announced ₹8,300 crore for a seven-year programme to combat air pollution in the national capital. The World Bank will provide 65 per cent of the funding, while the Delhi Government will bear the remaining 35 per cent.

According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the "Clean Air, Healthy Delhi" project will be implemented from September 2026 to August 2033 and will aim to strengthen air quality management and reduce emissions from major pollution sources across the city.

The project will accelerate the implementation of Delhi's air pollution mitigation plan, advance the objectives of the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) and contribute to the vision of 'Viksit Bharat 2047'.

The chief minister said a special workshop will be held on July 10 to finalise preparations for the programme and strengthen coordination



among all stakeholders. The workshop will define the roles of various departments and agencies and discuss the roadmap for the effective and timely implementation of the project, she said.

The Environment Department's project will cover key sectors contributing to pollution, including transport, road dust, construction and demolition waste, solid waste management, industries, green spaces and water pollution.

She said the initiative is not merely a pollution control programme but a long-term investment aimed at providing Delhi residents with cleaner air, better public

health and a more sustainable urban environment.

The chief minister added that the initiative rests on two major pillars, strengthening air quality management and reducing emissions from major pollution sources.

Under the first component, the government will establish a dedicated project management unit, develop advanced air quality monitoring systems, build data analytics capabilities and set up an integrated command and control centre-based monitoring system.

The project also envisages closer coordination with states in the Indo-Gangetic Plain, scientific planning,

public awareness campaigns and adoption of new technologies. The second component focuses on reducing emissions by phasing out older polluting vehicles, promoting electric vehicles, strengthening public transport and developing an advanced Pollution Under Control monitoring system for vehicle emissions.

According to the Chief Minister, all major departments and agencies of the Delhi Government will work together to ensure the successful implementation of the project.

These include the Environment Department, Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPPC), Transport Department, Public Works Department (PWD), Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Delhi Jal Board (DJB), Delhi Transco Limited (DTL), Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC), Delhi Traffic Police, Delhi Development Authority (DDA), New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), Delhi Cantonment Board (DCB), DSIIDC, DTIDC, DIMTS and other related institutions.

Eat till you drop: Delhi's mango festival is back

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Every summer, for a single afternoon, Dilli Haat in Janakpuri becomes the most democratic place in Delhi. You pay ₹100. You sit down. And then you eat mangoes, as many as you want, for as long as you can. Men on one side, women on the other, and somewhere in between, the quiet, sticky, entirely serious business of eating India's most beloved fruit until you cannot eat any more. The 35th Annual Mango Festival 2026, inaugurated by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday, is many things. But the eating competition is the soul of the thing.

The festival runs at Dilli Haat, Janakpuri, from noon to 9 pm daily until July 5, and it is organised by the Delhi Tourism Department with a scale that the numbers alone cannot fully convey. More than 400 varieties of mangoes have been brought from across the country and arranged under one roof. Some are as small as grapes. Some are as large as papayas.



There are Husnara, Rataul, Ramkela, Kesar, Mallika, Amrapali, Fazli, and Hathi Jhool, among dozens of others that most visitors have never seen in a market and possibly never will again outside this festival.

Mango growers from multiple states have made the journey, as have some of India's most important agricultural institutions: ICAR-Indian Agricultural Research Institute at Pusa, ICAR-Central Institute for Subtropical Horticulture in Lucknow, Govind Ballabh Pant

University of Agriculture and Technology in Pantnagar, Bihar Agricultural University, and the Directorate of Horticulture in Saharanpur. Individual growers, including Tariq Mustafa, Rambir, Akhlaq Ali, Mohammad Shahid, and Mohammad Junaid, have brought their finest produce.

Many of the varieties on display are the result of decades of careful grafting, selection, and experimentation by farming families who have spent their lives in orchards. The festival is, among other things, a living

archive of what Indian agriculture is capable of growing. Cabinet Ministers Kapil Mishra, Ashish Sood, and Manjinder Singh Sirsa were present at the inauguration alongside the Chief Minister.

The Chief Minister described the mango as an emotional symbol connected with Indian culture, family memories, and childhood in a way that no other fruit manages. She noted that Indian mangoes have become a tool of soft power internationally, with what she called Mango Diplomacy giving a new dimension to India's cultural and diplomatic relationships abroad.

India produces nearly half of the world's mangoes, holds close to 1,000 of the approximately 1,500 known varieties globally, and has been cultivating the fruit for nearly 4,000 years. All of that history comes to a single park in west Delhi for three days every July. Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra said the festival is part of a broader effort to reposition Delhi as a cultural destination rather than simply a transit city.



Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



Rekha Gupta
Chief Minister, Delhi

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IN FOCUS



Artisans working on the construction of chariots ahead of the Gundicha Yatra in Puri, Odisha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police have arrested three persons, including a former Punjab Police officer, in connection with an alleged ₹10-crore extortion racket targeting defence entrepreneur Sahil Luthra, Co-Founder and Managing Director of Vijayan Trishul Defence Solutions Private Limited (VTDS).

The case has assumed international dimensions with investigators zeroing in on an alleged Canada-based network. Luthra, whose company operates in India's strategically sensitive defence manufacturing sector, received repeated threatening WhatsApp messages and calls from foreign numbers. The extortionists allegedly invoked the names of Canada-based gangster Goldy Brar and Khalistani operatives to pressure him into paying the huge sum.

Acting swiftly on the complaint, a police team arrested Jaswant Singh, a former Punjab Police officer

who later joined Luthra's company as an employee. Along with him, Shamsher Singh alias Sam and Gurbinder Singh alias Prince were also taken into custody. According to investigators, Jaswant Singh played a key role in the conspiracy by allegedly providing a mobile phone and SIM card used to send the threatening messages.

"The messages clearly mentioned that the ₹10 crore should be transferred to certain individuals based in Canada," a senior police official said. "We are now examining the financial trail, digital footprints and possible overseas handlers who may have directed or benefited from the plot."

The probe has revealed that the accused allegedly conspired to exploit Luthra's position in the defence industry. Officials are analysing call detail records, international messaging apps, and financial data to uncover the full extent of the network. Indications of involvement of more persons, both in India and



abroad, have also surfaced.

The emergence of a Canada connection has added urgency to the investigation. Agencies are exploring possibilities of coordination with international law enforcement to trace the recipients and understand whether the extortion attempt was part of a larger syndicate operating across borders.

The defence sector angle has raised concerns over potential threats to national security-related enterprises. Police are conducting thorough background checks on the arrested individuals and examining their links with known criminal elements.

The investigation is progressing rapidly with technical support from cyber cells. Further arrests are expected as more evidence emerges.

All three accused are currently in police custody and being interrogated. As per legal norms, their guilt or innocence will be decided by the court after a fair trial.

SC stay procedural, not clean chit to discoms: Sood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Power minister Ashish Sood called a Supreme Court order staying an order of his department for CAG audit of power discoms in the city as "procedural" in nature and not a "clean chit" to the power distribution companies.

The Delhi Government had ordered a CAG audit of power discoms against the backdrop of a staggering Rs 38,500 crore accumulated over the years as Regulatory Assets (RA) that are to be recovered from consumers. The Court, while passing the order, said that the legality of the power regulator Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission's (DERC) decision to appoint the CAG gives rise to questions for a judicial determination. "The interim order passed by the Supreme Court is a proce-



dural order intended to preserve the status quo until the legal issues are examined in detail," Sood said in a statement.

It is neither a final verdict on the merits of the case nor a clean chit to the private power distribution companies, he stated. The Court has fixed the matter for hearing on July 15, where the legal framework governing

the audit mechanism will be examined. The Delhi Government has proceeded throughout this matter with complete honesty, transparency and in accordance with law, Sood said.

"We are fully prepared to place our case before the Supreme Court on 15 July and demonstrate why an independent and rigorous CAG audit is necessary to

safeguard the interests of Delhi's electricity consumers and taxpayers," he said.

The power minister said that the Supreme Court has "recognised" that important legal questions concerning transparency and accountability in Delhi's power sector deserve detailed consideration. An interim stay is not a victory for the discoms. The Court has not held that the CAG audit is illegal and has simply preserved the existing position while examining the legal framework.

"Significantly, the Court has also directed that liquidation of the Regulatory Assets will remain stayed until further orders. We welcome this protection extended by the Hon'ble Supreme Court in public interest," Sood said. This is a "major relief" for the people of Delhi because it prevents immediate imple-

mentation of a mechanism that could have ultimately translated into a massive financial burden on electricity consumers, he said.

The "resistance" to the audit raises serious questions, Sood said and added that the urgency with which discoms have attempted to prevent the CAG audit raises obvious questions. "If there is nothing to hide, there should be no objection to an independent public audit conducted under constitutional supervision," he said.

Delhi Government is fighting to protect Delhi's consumers, said the minister and added it can not allow a potential burden of nearly Rs 38,500 crore to be transferred onto the people of Delhi through higher tariffs and surcharges without strict and independent financial scrutiny.

Rains lash north India, three dead in Himachal Pradesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Southwest monsoon advanced further over the northern states on Friday, resulting in blocked roads, waterlogged streets and rain-related deaths.

Rajasthan witnessed widespread rainfall, while moderate rains lashed Himachal Pradesh, and it was uneven across Uttar Pradesh.

Cloudy skies shrouded the national capital Delhi a day after the monsoon arrived in the city, leading to muggy and humid conditions. Meanwhile, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday said the Centre is continuously monitoring the situation arising out of below-normal rainfall and "potential drought conditions" in certain parts of the country due to the 'El Nino' effect.



He has directed the agriculture and other ministries concerned to remain "vigilant", according to a Government statement.

Three rain-related deaths were reported in Himachal Pradesh in the 24 hours from 4 pm on Thursday. Two people were reportedly electrocuted in Kangra and Shimla districts, while another individual died after slipping from a height in Mandi district.

Delhi Govt to launch single digital platform for medical tourism services

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From hospital selection and treatment bookings to live patient tracking, translation services and post-treatment support, Delhi Government is planning to bring medical tourism services under a single digital platform.

The Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC), the nodal agency for the initiative, has floated a Request for Proposal (RFP) on Friday to appoint a strategic partner that will design, develop, operate and manage the Delhi



Medical and Wellness Tourism (DMWT) Platform and the broader medical tourism ecosystem across the National Capital Territory. According to the RFP, the selected

partner will be responsible for setting up and operating an end-to-end ecosystem at its own cost, including the development of a web portal, mobile applications for patients and healthcare providers and an administrative dashboard for Government authorities and empanelled stakeholders. The DMWT platform is envisioned as a single-window system for interstate and international medical travellers seeking treatment in Delhi, it said.

It will facilitate patient registration, verification of passports and medical visas, hospital selection, treatment package booking,

payments, patient tracking, multilingual support, grievance redressal and post-treatment follow-up services. Under the implementation schedule, the selected agency will have to establish a project office in Delhi within 30 days of the contract becoming effective and submit a detailed project report and implementation plan within 60 days and the initial version of the DMWT platform is expected to be launched within 120 days, it said.

The first phase of empanelment, targeted for completion within 180 days, will include at least five Joint Commission International-accredited hospi-

tals, 25 National Accreditation Board for Hospitals and Healthcare Providers-accredited or equivalent hospitals, 15 AYUSH centres and 30 ground service providers covering transport, hospitality, language assistance and concierge services, it said.

The project also aims to integrate hospitals, doctors, AYUSH centres, diagnostic laboratories, accommodation providers and transport operators on a common digital platform. It will include standardised treatment packages with transparent pricing, enabling patients to compare healthcare options before making bookings, it said. The

strategic partner will also provide end-to-end concierge services covering medical opinion coordination, visa assistance, travel planning, airport transfers, accommodation, language interpretation, hospital admission support, discharge coordination and tele-consultation after treatment, it said, adding a dedicated multilingual contact centre will operate round the clock to assist patients throughout their treatment journey. To promote Delhi as a global healthcare destination, the selected agency will undertake branding and marketing campaigns aligned with the national "Heal in India" initiative.

FROM PAGE - 1

ED flags ₹95 crore cash trail in Maoist-hit areas

The amount of money involved was large. According to the ED, nearly ₹95 crore was channelled into India through this mechanism. A significant portion of cash withdrawals occurred in LWE-affected areas, particularly in Chhattisgarh's Dhamtari and Bastar regions, where around ₹6.5 crore was withdrawn. Officials described the emergence of a "parallel cash-based economy" in Naxal violence-hit zones as a serious threat to national security and financial integrity.

Such networks, they noted, could facilitate the movement of illicit funds for unlawful activities.

TTI is not registered under the FCRA, so it cannot legally receive or use foreign contributions in India. The group is accused of using foreign debit cards to withdraw cash from ATMs in different states, without using approved Indian banks or obtaining the required permissions. The ED pointed out that these repeated large cash withdrawals were especially concerning in tribal and Maoist-affected areas.

Investigators believe these actions created an unregulated financial system outside the control of the Reserve Bank of India and the Ministry of Home Affairs. The ED's findings led to the registration of criminal cases. Police later filed FIRs under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) against TTI and six people after the ED's complaint.

These issues have national security implications. By contacting the CBI, the ED wants a focused investigation under the FCRA. This would look at the entire chain of foreign funding, the possible use of shell companies or operatives in India, any destruction of digital evidence, and exactly how funds were used in LWE areas, an official said.

The penalties include imprisonment, fines, and cancellation of permissions for organisations. In cases involving national security or LWE regions, the stakes are considerably higher. The Timothy Initiative describes itself as a global evangelical ministry focused on church planting and leadership development.

The ED probe, however, centres purely on the financial and regulatory violations, not on the organisation's religious objectives. India has also

tightened scrutiny of foreign funding to prevent misuse, money laundering, and activities detrimental to the national interest. The FCRA requires anyone who wants to accept foreign contributions to register or get permission first. The reported use of debit cards to set up a parallel funding network in insurgency-affected areas has made enforcement more challenging. Officials said this case shows why strong monitoring of cross-border money flows that avoid official systems is needed.

The ED's investigation is still ongoing. More information is expected once the case is officially sent to the CBI and as experts examine the seized devices and records. As attention to unregulated foreign money entering sensitive areas remains high, security agencies and regulators will keep a close watch on developments in the CBI probe, officials added.

SC pulls the plug on CAG audit of Delhi discoms

The SC was hearing the DERC's plea against an April ruling of the APTEL, which had held that entrusting the audit to the CAG was contrary to the statutory framework and directed the regulator to appoint an independent chartered accountant for the audit. The 2025 verdict came on the petitions filed by three power distribution companies against the DERC's tariff orders that led to the ballooning of RAs.

The SC on Friday, however, stayed both APTEL's direction requiring the appointment of an independent chartered accountant for conducting the audit and the fresh CAG audit initiated by the Delhi Government. "Till further orders, there shall be a stay of the APTEL direction on appointing any chartered accountant for audit. The CAG shall also not proceed with audit in the meantime," the Court ordered.

Beijing warns Delhi over Japan pact

Prime Minister Takaichi's visit also unfolded against the backdrop of worsening ties between Tokyo and Beijing. Bilateral relations have

remained strained since her November 2025 remarks that Japan could respond militarily if China were to attack Taiwan, comments that drew a sharp reaction from Beijing.

China regards the self-governed island of Taiwan as part of its territory and has repeatedly stated that it reserves the option of using force to achieve reunification.

The India-Japan initiative on critical minerals assumes added significance as China continues to tighten controls over rare earth exports to several countries, including India, Japan and the United States. Beijing dominates roughly 70 per cent of global rare earth mining and nearly 90 per cent of processing capacity, giving it considerable leverage over supplies essential for defence equipment, electric vehicles, renewable energy technologies, electronics and other advanced manufacturing sectors.

PM Modi to begin three-nation tour on July 6

He also highlighted Indonesia's pivotal role in ensuring the security and stability of the strategically important Malacca Strait, describing it as one of India's most critical sea lanes of communication and a vital maritime corridor for global trade.

The Prime Minister will then travel to Australia from July 8 to 10, where he will participate in the third India-Australia Annual Summit in Melbourne. The summit is expected to review progress in the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and explore new avenues of cooperation in critical minerals, cybersecurity, supply chain resilience, emerging technologies and other key sectors.

The final leg of the visit will be to New Zealand from July 10 to 11, where Mr Modi will hold bilateral talks with his New Zealand counterpart, Christopher Luxon. The visit will be the first by an Indian Prime Minister to New Zealand in nearly four decades, marking a significant milestone in bilateral relations.

Earlier on Friday, Prime Minister Luxon announced Mr Modi's upcoming visit, describing India as one of the world's largest and fastest-growing economies and an increasingly important partner for New Zealand's economic prosperity.

Luxon said the recently signed New Zealand-

India Free Trade Agreement would take bilateral ties to the next level by boosting exports, creating jobs and expanding economic opportunities. The agreement, signed earlier this year, is expected to enhance trade in goods and services while promoting greater investment flows between the two countries.

The three-nation visit reflects India's continued emphasis on strengthening partnerships across the Indo-Pacific region through closer strategic cooperation, enhanced economic engagement and deeper people-to-people and cultural ties.

Pranks gone rogue: Govt pulls down apps that...

BAT BMS and Epoch Li-ion are battery management apps that connect via Bluetooth and aid in remotely shutting down lithium-ion batteries. The apps are being used to carry out a "prank" and disable moving vehicles. BAT-BMS works within a Bluetooth range of roughly 15 metres and can connect to multiple batteries simultaneously. The app itself is marketed as a battery monitoring and management utility rather than a vehicle control application. Some BMS units lacked password protection or robust authentication, allowing anyone within Bluetooth range to pair with the battery and disable its discharge function, effectively immobilising the vehicle.

Lossigy and Epoch-i-ion (Epoch Li-ion) are similar BMS applications used with Bluetooth-enabled lithium batteries from other manufacturers. Many e-rickshaw drivers operating across Delhi's busy Metro corridors say they are living in fear after a smartphone application allegedly began shutting down their vehicles in the middle of the road without warning, leaving them stranded amid speeding traffic and exposing passengers to the risk of serious accidents.

Following the circulation of the videos, the Delhi Government has ordered a probe into the claims. Drivers plying on some of Delhi's busiest routes said that an unexpected shutdown on arterial roads could prove fatal as vehicles often travel close behind e-rickshaws, leaving little time to react.

Shree Ram, who ferries passengers between

Punjabi Bagh West Metro and Peeragarhi Metro, said the route witnesses heavy traffic throughout the day and e-rickshaws often have to wait for passengers on both ends. "I have heard that several e-rickshaws suddenly stopped on the main road. When a vehicle comes to a halt in the middle of traffic, it becomes dangerous as speeding vehicles approach from behind," Ram said. He said the situation could turn fatal for both passengers and drivers. "We constantly fear that someone may ram into us from behind," he said.

Ankush Kumar, who operates between West Enclave and Pitampura, said he initially believed repeated shutdowns were due to a battery malfunction.

"My e-rickshaw kept switching off. I thought there was a battery fault and spent Rs 500 to get it checked, but no defect was found. Later I came to know that everything was happening because of this Chinese app. When the vehicle stops, passengers refuse to pay and simply board another e-rickshaw. What may look like a joke to some people has become life-threatening for us on the road," he said.

Kumar said drivers were not only suffering financial losses but were also under constant mental stress while driving in congested traffic.

Another e-rickshaw driver Anuj Kumar, who operates on the Kohat Enclave-Netaji Subhash Place route, claimed that some people were allegedly locking batteries through the application. "Some people are locking the battery using the app. Now e-rickshaw drivers also have to download the same application to unlock it in an emergency. Sometimes only the person who has the app can unlock the battery. It is creating huge problems for drivers. If the e-rickshaw stops on the main road, it becomes a major safety risk. Police should take action against such app users," Kumar added.

According to a senior Delhi Government official, the app is primarily designed to monitor battery parameters such as voltage, temperature and current in real time, but its control functions could be misused on systems that lack adequate authentication.

"There is no password or authentication. As a result, cutting the power output and bringing the vehicle to a sudden halt becomes easy," the official said.

ECI appoints 10 IAS officers as observers to oversee SIR in Odisha



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The Election Commission of India (ECI) has appointed 10 senior IAS officers as Electoral Roll Observers (ERO) to oversee the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) in the state, according to a notification issued on Friday.

The draft voters' list for Odisha is scheduled to be published on July 5.

In a notification, the office of Odisha's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) named 10 senior officers as the ERO to oversee the SIR of electoral rolls in the state with effect from July 1.

They have been asked to visit the districts assigned to them at least thrice during the SIR work, the notification said. During the revision process, each officer will have to undertake at least three rounds of field visits including areas not within the district headquarters towns. The first visit will coincide with the period for receipt of claims and objections, with observers expected to be present in one of the districts under their charge on designated special campaign days, it said.

Bengal Govt working for people, taking along all MLAs: CM Suvendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday said the BJP Government in the State is trying to bring transformation in the administration by taking along all MLAs, including the Leader of Opposition, and working for the welfare of people.

Addressing the inaugural ceremony of an orientation programme for the newly-elected members of the West Bengal Legislative Assembly, Adhikari also said that besides the administration, even the Assembly used to function according to the directives from the ruling party's office earlier.

"Earlier, MPs or MLAs had no honour. They were not even invited to events by the BDOs and DMs. No invitation was sent to me for even administrative meetings. I was suspended from the Assembly five times. In all important Assembly sessions, I was suspended," he said. Besides the administration, even the Assembly used to function according to the directives from the ruling party's office, Adhikari said, without taking the name of the previous Trinamool Congress (TMC) Government in the State headed by Mamata Banerjee.



Before becoming the chief minister, Adhikari was the Leader of the Opposition in the West Bengal Assembly from 2021 to 2026. But now, the chief minister said, he is trying to bring changes in all spheres of the administration as well as give more responsibilities to the MPs and MLAs. He said now all MLAs and MPs, irrespective of their parties, would get an invitation from the administration for all events and meetings.

"I am taking along all MLAs irrespective of the party. We are working together with the Leader of the Opposition, too," he said. Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, Ritabrata Banerjee, was sitting on the dais when Adhikari spoke. Ritabrata Banerjee is the leader of the rebel TMC MLAs. The break-away faction has claimed the party's name, flag, symbol and control of its funds.

Adhikari said the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Government in West Bengal wants to strengthen democracy in the State and make the Assembly the best in the country. He said live telecast of the Assembly proceedings has already started. Assembly activities will be fully digitised, and other infrastructure of the House will be strengthened.

Adhikari said the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) Government in West Bengal wants to strengthen democracy in the State and make the Assembly the best in the country. He said live telecast of the Assembly proceedings has already started. Assembly activities will be fully digitised, and other infrastructure of the House will be strengthened.

Punjab ends livestock tax, ending Kashmir mutton crisis



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The Punjab Government has withdrawn the levy it had imposed on vehicles transporting livestock through the state, ending the mutton supply crisis in Kashmir.

Khazir Mohammad Regoo, president of the All Kashmir Wholesale and Retail Mutton Dealers Association, announced on Friday that the dispute over the alleged illegal levy on Kashmiri meat traders has been fully resolved.

Kashmir had been facing an acute shortage of mutton ever since the Punjab Government imposed a 4 per cent tax on vehicles carrying livestock through the State.

"The matter has been resolved after the Punjab authorities revoked the levy," Regoo said. He said the association had formed a coordination committee that camped in Punjab and took up the issue with the Government there. "Members of the coordination committee were in

Punjab for the last 10 days. They met several people in the Punjab Government. Thank God, the Government there understood that it was an illegal tax and revoked it," he said, expressing gratitude to political leaders, people, and media for their support.

Kashmiri traders had raised the issue with Chief Minister Omar Abdullah as well as other political leaders in the Valley. Jammu and

Kashmir National Conference Spokesman, Imran Nabi Dar, in a post on X, also confirmed, "Deadlock ended! Kudos to Chief Minister Omar Abdullah for his swift intervention in resolving the Mutton crisis with Punjab."

"Finally, relief for the people during the wedding season. Omar Abdullah's efforts ensured the resumption of livestock supply to Kashmir, bringing much-needed relief".



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Datia by-election triggers multi-cornered caste scramble

GIRISH SHARMA ■ Bhopal

The announcement of the Datia Assembly by-election has detonated a political scramble in one of Madhya Pradesh's most arithmetically complex constituencies, where no single caste commands a majority. Margins have historically been wafer-thin, and the outcome will be determined not by the strength of any one community but by the direction in which half a dozen fractured vote banks ultimately gravitate.

The BJP has moved with characteristic decisiveness, projecting former Home Minister Narottam Mishra as its singular and undisputed claimant — a heavy-weight candidature designed to reclaim a seat the party lost by just 7,742 votes in 2023. The Azad Samaj Party has fielded Damodar Yadav as its sole contender, positioning itself to splinter the OBC and Dalit vote. It is within the Congress, however, that the most convulsive internal battle is raging.

total force at approximately 95,000 voters — roughly 53 per cent of the total electorate — but this bloc is itself splintered across multiple sub-groups: Yadavs and Kushwaha-Kachhis (17,000), Lodhis (15,000), Baghel-Pals (10,000) and assorted other OBC communities (20,000). No single sub-caste within this constellation commands sufficient numbers to independently swing the result.

The two largest homogeneous caste groups are Brahmins and Ahirwars, each numbering approximately 33,000 - a striking numerical parity that encapsulates the constituency's inherent volatility. The BJP has traditionally enjoyed robust support among Brahmin voters, while Congress has maintained its foothold among Scheduled Caste communities, particularly the Ahirwar segment.

The general category electorate — encompassing Brahmins, Baniyas, Rajputs, Kayasths and Sindhis — totals approximately



Disqualified MLA Rajendra Bharti — whose removal from the Assembly triggered the by-election — is deploying every ounce of political capital to secure the ticket for his son Anuj, determined to preserve the family's custodianship of the constituency. Ranged against him is Avdesh Nayak, a former Textbook Corporation vice-chairman who abandoned the BJP for Congress ahead of the 2023 elections.

Nayak's claim carries a particular moral sting: the party had originally declared him as its candidate in 2023 before unceremoniously substituting Bharti following pressure from the latter's faction. Nayak now argues that his acquiescence then has earned him an irrevocable entitlement now. Former Datia MLA Ghanshyam Singh has added a third contour to the Congress's internal turbulence, further complicating the party's selection calculus.

The constituency's demographic architecture makes it among the most delicately balanced in Madhya Pradesh. Other Backward Classes constitute the dominant elec-

60,000, and any decisive consolidation of this vote behind one party could transform the contest from a cliffhanger into a rout. The Scheduled Caste electorate, estimated at 58,000, is anchored by the Ahirwar community but also includes Khatiks, Valmikis, Koris and Jatavs — sub-groups that hold booth-level influence capable of altering micro-margins across the constituency.

Muslim voters, numbering roughly 8,000, represent a slender but potentially decisive wedge in a contest where the last margin of victory was under 8,000. Political analysts are categorical: Datia cannot be won on the back of any single community.

The Brahmin vote, the Ahirwar vote, the Yadav-Kushwaha consolidation, the Lodhi bloc, the Muslim preference G whichever direction these five currents flow, the electoral tide will follow. The 2023 result — Congress's narrow 7,742-vote triumph — is a standing testament to this fragile equilibrium, where a marginal shift in any one demographic is sufficient to invert the outcome entirely.



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**जोधपुर एवं आस-पास के क्षेत्रों के पर्यटन उद्योग को बढ़ावा**

**क्षेत्र में आर्थिक विकास और रोज़गार के नए अवसरों का सृजन**

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PM to launch ₹1.06 lakh crore projects in Rajasthan, Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to undertake a high-profile whirlwind tour of Rajasthan and Gujarat on Saturday, during which he will dedicate and lay the foundation stones for massive development projects worth approximately Rs 1.06 lakh crore. The major highlights of the Prime Minister's multi-state itinerary include the rollout of a mega aviation connectivity scheme, the inauguration of India's premier greenfield refinery-cum-petrochemical complex, and a massive boost to the nation's semiconductor ecosystem.

The Prime Minister will commence his visit in Rajasthan at Jodhpur around 10:45 am, where he is set to unveil the newly constructed Jodhpur Airport Terminal Building. Built at a cost of Rs 480 crore, the heritage-inspired, eco-friendly terminal is designed to manage 20 lakh passengers annually.



On this occasion, he will launch the Modified UDAN scheme. Backed by a whopping 10-year allocation of Rs 28,840 crore, this revamped initiative intends to modernise 100 unserved airstrips and establish 200 high-tech helipads across difficult terrains, heavily prioritising indigenous aircraft like the HAL Dhruv and Dornier platforms.

Moving to Balotra later in the afternoon, the Prime Minister will dedicate India's first greenfield integrated refinery-cum-petrochemical complex at Pachpadra.

Developed as a joint venture between HPCL and the Rajasthan Government with an investment exceeding Rs 79,450 crore, the state-of-the-art 9 MMTPA facility aims to significantly augment the country's energy security and downstream plastic industries.

While in Balotra, Modi will also lay the foundation stone for the Rs 13,000-crore Phase 2 of the Jaipur Metro Rail Project, spanning a 41-km north-south corridor with 36 stations.

His developmental packet for the desert state further

encompasses the Churu-Sadulpur and Churu-Ratangarh rail doubling projects, solar energy ventures in Bikaner by SJVN and NHPC totalling 1,300 MW, and power transmission infrastructure worth over Rs 1,900 crore. In a major employment push, the Prime Minister will also distribute appointment letters to nearly 54,000 youth recruited across various Rajasthan Government departments.

Later in the evening, the Prime Minister will travel to Sanand in Ahmedabad, Gujarat, to inaugurate the state-of-the-art CG SEMI Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (OSAT) facility. Established under the India Semiconductor Mission with an investment of over ₹7,500 crore, the facility boasts an ultimate capacity of manufacturing 5 billion chips annually to power AI, automotive, and 5G sectors, marking a seminal milestone in India's quest for chip self-reliance.

Environment Ministry proposes targets to curb emissions in iron and steel sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Environment Ministry has issued a draft notification to set legally binding emission reduction targets for the iron and steel sector under the Greenhouse Gases Emission Intensity (GEI) Target (Amendment) Rules, 2025.

The draft notification published on Thursday sets targets for 255 iron and steel

units. These include Tata Steel in Jharkhand, JSW Steel in Karnataka, and Jindal Steel and Power in Chhattisgarh.

With the draft notification, the total number of carbon-intensive industries required to comply with the framework has risen to nine, the other eight being aluminium, secondary aluminium (made from recycled scrap), petroleum refinery, petrochemical, textile industries,



cement, chlor-alkali, and pulp and paper.

All these sectors are under the purview of the country's domestic carbon market as

part of the Carbon Credits Trading Scheme (CCTS) launched in 2023.

The scheme incentivises reductions in carbon dioxide emissions and supports the country's climate action commitments under the 2015 Paris Climate Agreement. If industries achieve the legally binding targets, they earn carbon credits, which can be sold to industries that fail to meet the targets.

DAC clears ₹52,000 cr military procurements

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Giving a major fillip to enhance capabilities to fight modern-day wars, the Government on Friday gave the go-ahead to proposals worth over ₹52,000 crore to procure anti-drone systems and sophisticated surveillance and intelligence-gathering satellites for the Army and IAF.



Missile (MPATGM) Systems, Medium Range Surface-to-Air Missile (MRSAM) Weapon System, Very Short Range Air Defence System (V-SHORADS), Active Protection System for Tanks and Jet-Based Kamikaze Drone System.

Akash Tarang will provide effective anti-UAV protection to the Army Formations. The MPATGM will enhance the potential of the infantry to counter mechanised threats posed by the adversary. The MRSAM system provides medium-range air defence against a variety of stand-off aerial threats.

The V-SHORADS with multi-spectral sensing will enhance counter-measure resilience and effectiveness of the Indian Army. The Active Protection System will be capable of improving the defence mechanism of tanks

and enhancing their survivability. The Jet-Based Kamikaze Drones provide better Electronic Warfare capability with greater lethality and survivability while also being cost-effective.

For the Indian Navy, approval was given for the procurement of Multi Influence Ground Mine (MIGM), Naval Shipborne Unmanned Aerial System (NSUAS) and the setting-up of Land Based Testing Facility (LBTF) for Electric Propulsion System.

The MIGM will deny freedom of manoeuvre to the adversary. The NSUAS, equipped with advanced sensors, will enhance situational awareness of the Indian Navy. The LBTF will meet the testing requirements for the motors and associated Propulsion Systems of the Indian Naval assets.

CM Suwendu offers to transform West Bengal from Didi era

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday launched a blistering attack on his predecessor Mamata Banerjee, saying hers was the worst Government the State had seen — since Independence — and calling upon all the legislators to join him in building a democratically strong and performing Bengal.

Speaking at the opening session of a two-day orientation programme of the newly elected Members of the State Legislative Assembly, inaugurated by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, the Chief Minister said, referring to Banerjee, that “most unfortunately never since Independence” Bengal “fared so poorly under any Chief Minister.” Adhikari's statement came in tandem with his Government's decision to seize wage distribution powers in the 125-day work scheme from the hands of the Panchayat Pradhans — often considered the ‘king-makers at the lowest level’.

The Chief Minister said that during the previous Government, main policy decisions routinely came from the party offices and were not decided on the floors of the Assembly. “I don't want to launch political attacks or say negative things but only ...



place the facts before the newly elected legislators” he said, adding his Government wanted all the MLAs from all the parties to be a part of the administrative meetings, reminding how during the previous Government no opposition party MLAs were called to administrative meetings. Giving an account of how he, as an Opposition Leader was treated during the last five years by the TMC Government he said, “I was Opposition Leader for five years and was suspended for five times ... mostly during the Budget and important session when decisions were taken,” advising the first timers to even those from the Opposition join him “in the development of the State together.”

The Chief Minister stressed Bengal's “Gateway of the East” status, often underscored by Prime Minister Narendra Modi saying it was his wish to restore the democratic institutions in the State

and work towards maximising the State's natural and industrial resources under the guidance of the Prime Minister. “We now want to make Bengal stand on its feet,” he said.

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, who inaugurated the programme, called upon the new legislators to contribute towards building a new Bengal and carry forward the work of the renaissance by strengthening the democratic traditions, reminding them that the people's representatives were the custodians of the people's aspirations.

Stressing the growing role of technology, Birla said that the digital era had opened the doors for the legislators to access legislative debates, policy documents, and best practices from Parliament and State Legislatures. Referring to the Digital Sansad platform, he said that the Members could now benefit from a vast repository of parliamentary knowledge and comparative legislative experiences.

Adhikari also proposed to introduce the digital era in the Bengal Assembly. Adhikari's discernible mention of the 15-year Mamata Banerjee rule, pockmarked with scams, came amidst his decision to free the 100-days work regime from corruption.

This, even as his Government decided to seize wage disbursing power from the village panchayat pradhans. Earlier the panchayat pradhans used to decide who would get the wages under the 100 days' work scheme — now rechristened G RAM G scheme “but now the Government officials will be entrusted with that task because in most of the cases the workers' money used to the pockets of the party men or Pradhan's henchmen,” Bengal Minister Agnimitra Paul said hailing the decision of the CM.

There are about 147 jobs that fall within the G RAM G (Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission — Gramin) scheme, she said, driving home the point that Adhikari said, “Government has embarked on uprooting corruption from the grassroots.” The Centre has upgraded the job project to 125 days per year with an upward revision of the wages from about ₹230 to ₹300 per day.

States Focus



CONGRESS, BRS SPAR OVER TELANGANA DEBT BURDEN

The ruling Congress and Opposition BRS in Telangana continued to spar for the second day on Friday over debt burden, with Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka stating that a debt of over ‘8.21 lakh crore was made during the previous BRS regime. Slamming BRS leaders KT Rama Rao and T Harish Rao for downplying the debt burden, he also said the BRS is carrying out a Goebbels campaign against the Congress Government over various issues. He alleged that it was BRS president K Chandrasekhra Rao who “destroyed” the state when he was the chief minister. (PTI)



JAGDEEP DHANKHAR UNDERGOES ANGIOPLASTY IN JAIPUR

Former vice president Jagdeep Dhankhar underwent angioplasty at a private hospital in Jaipur on Friday, hospital sources said. Dhankhar was admitted to a hospital near Jawahar Circle for routine medical examinations. Following cardiac investigations, doctors advised angioplasty, which was performed later in the day. Sources said the procedure was part of a pre-planned cardiac evaluation.

Former chief minister Ashok Gehlot visited Dhankhar at the hospital and enquired about his health. Gehlot said Dhankhar was undergoing treatment under the supervision of noted cardiologist Dr Sameen Sharma, who had come from United States. (PTI)

Massive reshuffle in West Bengal lower police administration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

In a major reshuffle at the subaltern section of the State police administration, the Bengal Government transferred 108 police inspectors posted in various districts, police stations and specialised units, including the CID and GRP throughout the State.

The decision was communicated via a notification issued by the Home Department late Thursday night, sources said, adding that a number of police officers had been shifted out of the sensitive police station areas, whereas some important police stations in Howrah and Kolkata got new police officers too.

“These are all routine transfers that continue to take place from time to time ... the officers have been asked to join their new postings immediately,” an IGP-level officer said.



Amit Shah reviews El Niño rainfall deficit, flood damage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On Friday, Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan met to discuss the impact of below-normal rainfall in some parts of the country, which has been linked to El Niño. Senior officials from important ministries, such as the Home Secretary and Agriculture Secretary, were also present.

Shah said the Government is monitoring the low rainfall and the risk of drought in affected areas. He told the Ministry of Agriculture and other related ministries to work with State Governments and guide farmers on which crops to plant. Shah also asked the



Department of Water Resources to monitor reservoir levels nationwide and suggested focusing on crops that require less water, such as fodder, millets, and pulses.

The Home Minister asked the Secretary of the Power Ministry to ensure a steady and sufficient supply of electricity. Officials told him that there are enough stocks of

important food grains like rice and wheat, and that prices are stable.

The Home Minister told the Inter-Ministerial Central Team from the Ministry of Home Affairs to visit Assam and Arunachal Pradesh to assess the damage caused by recent heavy rain, floods, and landslides. Assam has seen floodwaters rise across

several districts, and Arunachal Pradesh has faced landslides and road blockages. The team's visit will help determine the extent of damage to infrastructure, farms, and homes.

Secretaries from important departments, including Agriculture, Water Resources, Consumer Affairs, Fisheries, Environment, Power, Rural Development, and Science and Technology, attended the meeting. Representatives from the National Disaster Management Authority, the India Meteorological Department, the Central Water Commission, the Indian Agricultural Research Institute, and the National Remote Sensing Centre were also present.

El Niño to strengthen rapidly, risk of extreme weather: WMO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

El Niño conditions in the tropical Pacific are expected to strengthen rapidly in the coming months, increasing the risk of heatwaves, droughts, heavy rainfall and other extreme weather events across many parts of the world, the World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) said on Friday. The organisation's monthly ‘WMO Global Seasonal Climate Update’ indicates a rapid development into a strong El Niño event during July-September this year.

El Niño is one of the three phases of the El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO), a climate phenomenon characterised by changes in sea temperatures along the



central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean, accompanied by fluctuations in the atmosphere overhead.

While El Niño is known to have a warming effect on the planet, its opposite phase, called La Niña, usually results in a cooling effect. ENSO also has a neutral phase.

In a statement, WMO Secretary-General Celeste Saulo said, “El Niño conditions are already underway and are forecast to strengthen

en rapidly into a strong event as accurately anticipated by WMO forecasts.

“This will intensify the chances of drought and heavy rainfall and the risk of heatwaves on land and marine heatwaves in many regions of the world.” On June 12, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) declared the onset of El Niño conditions and said that they would strengthen further during the southwest

monsoon season.

El Niño conditions typically lead to less rainfall in India. They were one of the key reasons why, in June, the country as a whole witnessed a rainfall deficit of about 40 per cent, with central India worst affected with a deficit of 50.4 per cent.

In its June 30 forecast, the IMD said the monthly average rainfall over India is expected to be below normal during July. The weather department said July is most likely to see 94 per cent of the long-period average rainfall (1971-2020). The LPA rainfall over India in July is about 280.4 mm. LPA refers to the rainfall recorded over a particular region for a given period, such as a month or a season, averaged over a long period, typically 30 to 50 years.

Channi row: Punjab Congress rift out in open

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi's supporters gathered at his residence in Punjab's Morinda on Friday, with many former MLAs demanding that he be made the state unit chief.

The development comes after the party's central leadership decided to retain Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the state unit chief. The announcement to retain Warring came on Wednesday, alongside the unveiling of the party's various committees for the 2027 Assembly polls.

Before the supporters started to gather at Channi's Morinda residence, some former party MLAs, who reached Channi's residence, told reporters that if the Congress has to come to power in Punjab in the next year's election, the former chief minister should be made the president of the State unit.

Channi is said to be miffed at not being appointed to the post. He is learnt to have not even made a customary call to thank the party leadership following the new announcements.

Channi's supporters have expressed disappointment



over not being given the post for which the former Punjab chief minister had been lobbying hard.

Among those who reached Channi's residence were former deputy chief minister OP Soni, former ministers Bharat Bhushan Ashu and Gurpreet Singh Kangar, former MP Mohd Sadiq, sitting MLA Tript Rajinder Singh Bajwa, ex-MLAs Nazar Singh Manshahia, Gurkirat Singh Kotli, Lakhvir Singh Lakha, Darshan Singh Brar and Tarsem Singh.

Before the meeting, several supporters of Channi, including some former MLAs, threw weight behind him demanding that party should

hand over reins of Punjab Congress to the ex-CM. Ex-MLA Darshan Singh Brar said, "If Channi is not made the state president, the Congress cannot form its Government in Punjab. Under Warring's leadership, the Congress cannot come to power".

Gurpreet Kangar said, "We have to go to people to seek votes and people want Channi as the state chief." Amid talks of a change in the leadership of its Punjab unit, the Congress decided to retain Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the State unit president.

Jalandhar MP Channi, a Dalit, who was seen as one of the main contenders for the post of Punjab Congress

NEW CRACKS EMERGING IN CONGRESS: BJP

New Delhi: The BJP on Friday claimed that "new cracks" are emerging in the Congress, citing reports that party leader Charanjit Channi is "miffed" over the latest organisational reshuffle ahead of the Punjab polls.

The attack came a day after Congress leader Manish Tewari put out a cryptic post on X, saying he wished he had an antidote for the "insecurities of individuals" and "institutions" after he was not assigned any organisational role in the latest reshuffle in the state.

Tewari shared a media report which stated that he was "left in the cold" as the Congress appointed new working presidents and set up poll panels for Punjab.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said that the opposition party is in "tukde tukde mode" and facing infighting across states. "After Manish Tewari, now it is Channi's turn.



Tewari was upset with the Congress and tweeted about it. A day later, Channi, who is also upset with the Congress, is calling a meeting of his supporters," he said in a video statement.

Poonawalla claimed that the party was coasting headless. "It seems the Congress is giving evidence every day that it has no neta, no niti, no netriva, no mission – only confusion and division," he said.

Citing factional rivalries in several states, the BJP leader alleged that internal conflicts have become the defining feature of the Congress. (PNS)

chief, has been appointed chairperson of the campaign committee, an important position for strategising and planning the party's poll campaign.

The party also did not make any change in the position of the leader of

opposition in the Punjab Vidhan Sabha, which is currently held by Partap Singh Bajwa. Gurdaspur MP and former deputy chief minister Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa has been appointed chairperson of the core committee.

NHAI suspends officials after Dehradun Expressway cave-in

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After a video of a section of the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway caving in went viral, NHAI has suspended the team leader of the authority engineer and the project manager of the contractor even as it said the cave-in was due to water stagnation following rains.

The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) in a statement, said it has also issued show cause notices to the concerned project director, authority engineer and EPC contractor. A road surface cave-in observed on the Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor on July 1, 2026 was the result of localised water stagnation following rainfall the previous night, coupled with constraints in commissioning the permanent cross-drainage system at the location, NHAI said.

"NHAI regrets the inconvenience caused to NH commuters due to the road surface cave-in at a location on the Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor following rainfall. The section has been restored and opened for regular traffic movement," it said in a post



on X. According to NHAI, the permanent cross-drainage system at the location could not be commissioned due to sustained resistance from local residents, who did not permit integration of the balancing culvert and instead used the culvert opening as a vehicular crossing.

"Taking serious cognisance of the incident, show cause notices have been issued to the concerned project director, authority engineer and EPC contractor, while the team leader of the authority engineer and the project manager of the contractor have been suspended," it said. Following the incident, NHAI said it immediately undertook restoration works and has commenced con-

struction of an interim parallel drain to ensure safe disposal of rainwater until the permanent drainage system can be commissioned.

The affected location is under continuous monitoring to ensure safe and uninterrupted traffic movement, it added. The 213 km-long six-lane access-controlled corridor has been built at a cost of over Rs 12,000 crore.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway on April 14, 2026.

The corridor traverses through Delhi, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand and reduces travel time between Delhi and Dehradun from over six hours to around two-and-a-half hours now.

Amarnath Yatra: Second batch of over 3800 pilgrims leave Jammu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Amid tight security, the second batch of more than 3,800 pilgrims left the Jammu base camp on Friday for the Amarnath cave shrine in the south Kashmir Himalayas, officials said.

The 57-day pilgrimage to the 3,880-metre-high Amarnath cave shrine started on Friday morning simultaneously via the traditional 48-km Nunwan-Pahalgam route in the Anantnag district and the shorter but steeper 14-km Baltal route in the Ganderbal district. The yatra will conclude on August 28.

As many as 3,865 pilgrims left the Bhagwati Nagar base camp in a cavalcade of 201 vehicles escorted by security personnel and the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs), they said.

Of the total pilgrims, 1,735 were headed for the Baltal base camp in 115 vehicles, while 2,130 pilgrims in 86 vehicles were proceeding to the traditional Pahalgam base camp in the Anantnag district.

The atmosphere at the Bhagwati Nagar base camp was charged with devotion as pilgrims chanted "Bam Bam Bhole", "Har Har Mahadev"



Amarnath Yatra pilgrims riding ponies wave as they proceed towards the holy cave shrine via the Baltal route in Ganderbal district of J&K PTI

and "Jai Barfani Baba Ki" before embarking on their journey. Many expressed satisfaction over the arrangements made for the smooth and peaceful conduct of the pilgrimage.

On Thursday, the first batch of 4,822 pilgrims was flagged off from Bhagwati Nagar by Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha. With the fresh departure, a total of 8,687 pilgrims have left the Jammu base camp for the valley since Thursday. Authorities have put in place multi-layered security arrangements along the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway and at all transit camps to ensure the safe and smooth movement of the yatra convoys. A multi-tier security setup has been activated in and around the Bhagwati Nagar base camp for the annual pilgrimage.

PM EXTEND GREETINGS ON AMARNATH YATRA

New Delhi: Vice President C P Radhakrishnan and Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday greeted devotees on the commencement of the 57-day Amarnath Yatra. In a two-page letter to pilgrims, Modi urged them to take five pledges, including maintaining cleanliness and promote the 'vocal for local' campaign by supporting local businesses in Jammu and Kashmir. He also asked the devotees to follow instructions related to security and traffic movement during the pilgrimage. Noting that the yatra will conclude on Raksha Bandhan, he asked pilgrims to gift their brothers and sisters a sapling to promote greenery.

BJP seeks ₹51,000 payout for women over AAP scheme delay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon on Friday said the Punjab Government should transfer ₹51,000 to every woman in the State, ₹1,000 for every month AAP has been in Government, for delay in financial aid promised ahead of the last elections.

Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday rolled out his Government's monthly financial assistance scheme for women - 'Mawan Dhyan Satkar Yojna', and said the AAP has fulfilled its final poll 'guarantee' made ahead of the 2022 assembly elections.

Under the scheme, women from the general category will receive ₹1,000 per month, while those belonging to the Scheduled Castes will receive ₹1,500.

Mann said more than 40 lakh women have already been regis-



Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon

tered under the "landmark" initiative. Speaking to reporters here, state BJP chief Dhillon said Mann Government has cheated the women of Punjab.

"We demand that the Government immediately transfer ₹51,000, the total amount due for 51 months of AAP rule in Punjab, as per the third guarantee given by AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal on November 21, 2021, during a programme titled 'Kejriwal di Teeji

Guarantee, Mahilavan Nu Vadhaiyan' in Moga," Dhillon said.

Dhillon, who was flanked by Punjab BJP leader Vineet Joshi, claimed the "delay" in the rollout of the scheme a "historic betrayal".

First, by transferring only ₹1,000 per month to general category women and ₹1,500 per month to Scheduled Caste women, the Mann Government has effectively denied the ₹51,000 due for 51 months under Kejriwal's original promise of ₹1,000 per month to every eligible woman, he said.

The AAP came to power in Punjab in March 2022. "Second, Kejriwal's guarantee was for every woman above 18 years of age in Punjab, covering more than 1.25 crore women. Yet, the Mann Government claims to have transferred money to only 36 lakh women, meaning over 89 lakh women have been denied even the promised ₹1,000 assistance," Dhillon

said. The AAP has mastered the art of misleading people through false claims and propaganda, the BJP leader alleged. He said Kejriwal had claimed at the Moga rally that he delivers on his promises.

But in reality, this promise appears to have been a calculated attempt to mislead Punjab's women and secure votes through false guarantees when Punjab polls were barely few months away, Dhillon said. Dhillon said that Kejriwal had then claimed that there was no shortage of money for the scheme and that stopping ₹20,000 crore worth of illegal sand mining would finance the initiative.

"But after AAP came to power, illegal mining has not stopped; rather it has increased manifold," Dhillon alleged. The Punjab BJP chief asserted that BJP will continue to fight for Punjab's women until every promised rupee reaches their bank accounts.

Adi Kailash Yatra suspended due to monsoon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pithoragarh

The Adi Kailash and Om Parvat Yatra in Uttarakhand's Pithoragarh has been suspended in view of the monsoon, risk of landslides and safety of pilgrims, officials said on Friday. Dharchula Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) Ashish Joshi said that 52,441 pilgrims visited Adi Kailash and Om Parvat within two months of the commencement of the



pilgrimage on May 1. "Inner Line Permits for the Adi Kailash and Om Parvat Yatra will now be issued only after further orders," he said.

Joshi said that 103 pilgrims were last issued permits on July 1 before the suspension came into effect. The Adi Kailash pilgrimage in Pithoragarh began in 1981 — alongside the Kailash Yatra in Tibet — but gained popularity following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit on October 12, 2023.

UCC bill to be passed in West Bengal Assembly in August: Senior official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The bill for implementation of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in West Bengal will be passed in the assembly next month, a senior functionary of the state government said on Friday.

The West Bengal cabinet on Thursday approved the formation of a committee to examine the draft UCC bill and the panel will have four weeks to scrutinise the draft legislation and submit its recommendations.

"August is a month of many significant events in the country.

The Quit India movement began this month. India got independence in August.

Khudiram Bose was martyred in August and there are many other historical events. By August this year, another significant event will happen. We will pass the UCC bill in Bengal assembly," the functionary said.

Earlier this week, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari formally launched the process to implement the UCC in West Bengal.

Since 2014, three states have adopted the UCC bills — Uttarakhand, Gujarat and Assam

and West Bengal is set to become the fourth. The West Bengal UCC bill aims to standardise civil laws across all communities regarding marriage, divorce, inheritance, and adoption. The bill is similar to the models in Uttarakhand and Assam in key parameters.

The UCC was one of the BJP's key electoral promises in the 2026 Assembly polls. The party came to power ending the Trinamool Congress's 15-year rule in the state. Talking about the priorities of the BJP government in Bengal, the functionary said every month, at least two



new industries are coming to the state and the trend will continue for many months to come. Adhikari on June 12 had said that his government would bring the Tata Group back to the state.

However, he had said, the land at Singur on which Tata Motors had set up a car factory is no longer with the state government as it had been returned to the farmers by the previous Mamata Banerjee-led government.

The functionary also said that ever since the BJP government came to power in West Bengal, about 10,000 illegal immigrants

were handed over to the Bangladeshi authorities along the border after verifying their Bangladeshi nationality.

About 1,800 more illegal Bangladeshi immigrants are kept in holding centres in West Bengal and they would also be sent back to the neighbouring country.

On June 23, Adhikari had said his government has identified thousands of illegal immigrants and begun deporting them while assuring genuine Indian citizens they would not be affected, irrespective of their faith.

Help the common man, LS speaker Om Birla tells new Bengal MLAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla asked the newly elected MLAs of West Bengal on Friday to make efforts to change the life of the last person in society while fulfilling the hopes of the common people.

Addressing the inaugural ceremony of an orientation programme for the newly elected members of the West Bengal Legislative Assembly, Birla also said a developed West Bengal is necessary to build a developed India by 2047. He said each MLA represents their area as well as the collective aspirations of people.

"Their aim should always be to



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh Narayan Singh, Union Minister Kiren Rijiju, West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari, Leader of Opposition in the State Assembly Ritabrata Banerjee and others at a two-day orientation programme for the newly-elected members of the State Assembly in Kolkata PTI

change the life of the last person while fulfilling the hopes of the common people of Bengal," Birla said. He said great visionaries from West Bengal played a crucial role in social reformation and the struggle for freedom, along with spirituality, religion and culture.

"Bengal gave voice to the freedom movement with the proclamation of 'Vande Mataram'. The MLAs should work tirelessly to enrich the heritage, spiritual consciousness and cultural renaissance of Bengal again.

They should make all efforts for making India a developed country and empower the democracy with democratic dialogue," he said.

The Lok Sabha speaker said there

may be agreement and disagreement, but the tradition of democracy and excellent dialogue should remain intact.

He said the newly elected MLAs should learn from the experiences of old and experienced members and study old proceedings of the Assembly. "The newly elected MLAs should have a desire to learn and understand, a desire for innovation," he said. Birla said legislative members keep themselves updated in the times of AI technology and digitalisation.

"The newly elected members should sit in the House for maximum time and listen to the statements of other MLAs," he said.

Paswan promises justice in Bharat Tiwari killing case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhojpur

Union Minister Chirag Paswan on Friday said police officials allegedly responsible for the killing of Bharat Tiwari in Bihar's Bhojpur district would face strict punishment.

Tiwari, a resident of Bilauti village within Shahpur police station limits, allegedly opened fire on a police team with an illegal firearm when officers attempted to arrest him on June 17, officials said.

Police claimed they retaliated in self-defence, during



which Tiwari sustained bullet injuries and later died while undergoing treatment.



Editor's
TAKE

Delhi and Tokyo rewrite their strategic compact

As geopolitical tensions rise, Delhi and Tokyo are positioning themselves as trusted strategic partners, in an increasingly uncertain world

The optics were carefully choreographed – a ceremonial reception at Rashtrapati Bhavan, a santoor session recalling Takaichi's days as a college drummer, and Modi's warm invocation of her as "meri chhoti behen." But beneath the pageantry lay a substantive recalibration. The two prime ministers stressed the strategic salience of the India-Japan partnership in an increasingly volatile geopolitical environment and agreed to advance cooperation in three priority areas: economic security, energy resilience and technology.

That framing is telling. This is no longer a relationship built primarily on Japanese aid and infrastructure financing, the template of the past two decades. Both governments are now working to reduce vulnerabilities in global supply chains, particularly in semiconductors, critical minerals and advanced manufacturing, and – perhaps most significantly – they signed an agreement on their first joint defence co-development project, the naval radio antenna effort dubbed "Unicorn." For two countries that have historically kept defence cooperation at arm's length compared to their economic ties, this is a genuine step-change, one Modi framed as opening a new chapter in defence technology partnership. The China factor hovers over all of it, even if never named outright in the joint statements. Modi and Takaichi discussed the situation in the Indo-Pacific, a region that has witnessed growing Chinese military muscle-flexing, and the drive toward resilient supply chains is explicitly aimed at reducing dependence on China for critical minerals and active pharmaceutical ingredients. Add to this the disruption from West Asia's conflict – which has exposed vulnerabilities in the movement of critical goods and energy – and the summit reads less like ceremony and more like risk management between two trading nations trying to insulate themselves from a world of choke points. On technology, the two sides leaned into complementarity rather than competition. Modi's formulation – that the convergence of Japan's precision technology and India's software capabilities would impart new momentum to global AI development – captures the pitch both governments are making to investors: Japan brings hardware and industrial discipline, India brings scale and digital talent.

The Japan-India Economic Forum pulled in over 150 Japanese companies and produced 120 fresh business agreements, alongside pacts spanning clean energy, healthcare and biotechnology. Three takeaways stand out. First, defence cooperation has crossed a symbolic threshold, with Tokyo's review of its arms-transfer principles opening the door to deeper co-development beyond token gestures. Second, "economic security" has replaced "connectivity" as the organising vocabulary of the relationship – a shift that mirrors how both nations now think about China and West Asia simultaneously. Third, the personal rapport between Modi and Takaichi, still new to her role, suggests continuity of India-Japan warmth across a change of Japanese leadership. The biggest takeaway, however is, that Delhi and Tokyo intend to be each other's hedge against an unpredictable world – this maiden visit has done its job.

The 11 year legacy of digital India

By ensuring that technology acts as a tool for inclusion, accessibility, and sovereign strength, Digital India is quietly architecting the Viksit Bharat we envision for 2047



S KRISHNAN

Just over a decade ago, a farmer in a remote village in Uttar Pradesh had to navigate a maze of paperwork to receive subsidies or seek advisories to improve his yield. It was an era when waiting in line was the norm. Today, the same farmer can access support for his crops, and subsidies are deposited directly into his bank account without middlemen.

Walk down any street and you will witness another quiet revolution, one that has fundamentally redefined the ease of living. A local fruit seller or an autorickshaw driver who once relied entirely on the physical exchange of cash, now proudly points to a QR code hanging from his cart/autorickshaw.

India today stands empowered by a staggering 102.86 Crore connected citizens, supported by a massive broadband subscriber base of 99.56 Crore. With the cost of mobile data at an ultra-affordable 78 to 710 per GB, individual monthly data usage has scaled to an extraordinary 24.01 GB. This digital foundation has completely reimaged the relationship between the citizen and the state, anchoring it in trust, transparency, and digital autonomy.

Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, Digital India has proven that technology must act as a democratic equalizer for citizens bringing them ease of living and ease of doing business.

Bridging the Divide

The first step in this revolution was democratizing access and building a robust, indigenous digital identity framework that guarantees technological self-reliance. The BharatNet initiative was deployed at scale, successfully connecting nearly 2.2 Lakh Gram Panchayats with high-speed broadband, ensuring that geography is no longer a barrier to economic opportunity.

This infrastructural leap, coupled with the generation of 144+ Crore Aadhaar identities, powered the Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, and Mobile (JAM) Trinity. By utilizing this sovereign digital identity framework, the government has successfully transferred 751.5 Lakh Crore directly to citizens through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). This system has effectively eliminated leakage, removed middlemen, and dramatically improved the ease of living for millions of households by putting financial autonomy directly into their hands.

The DPI Phenomenon

Once the foundation was laid, India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) changed the every-



facilitating ease of living. Through the eSanjeevani platform, India has delivered over 48+ Crore free tele-consultations, allowing patients in remote, underserved areas to consult specialists. Similarly, the world's largest vaccination drive was powered by an indigenous platform. Over 220 crore COVID-19 vaccine doses were administered and tracked transparently through CoWIN, establishing a robust digital backbone that healthcare systems across the globe studied.

Looking at the Horizon

As Digital India completes its 11th year, the mission is firmly pivoting toward frontier technologies, ensuring they are harnessed as public goods to solve challenges for India and the Global South.

For years, the massive cost of computing power kept brilliant young innovators in smaller towns away from advanced technology. Under the IndiaAI Mission, India is systematically dismantling this barrier to boost the ease of doing business for startups. The government has established a massive, shared compute facility to democratize access. By offering world-class computing capacity to homegrown startups and students at just 765 per hour, the aim is to spark grass-roots innovation. The goal is to make India the AI Applications capital of the world with our talented workforce transforming service delivery and boosting productivity in enterprises in all sectors at home and abroad.

Simultaneously, India is securing its hardware future. Under the Semicon India Programme, 12 Semiconductor manufacturing and packaging projects with an investment of 71.65 Lakh Crore have now been approved across the country. Building on this momentum, the Union Budget 2026-27 announced the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0.

This new phase goes beyond manufacturing by focusing on semiconductor equipment and materials, designing full-stack Indian Intellectual Property (IP), and fortifying global supply chains. With 24 semiconductor design startups approved under the scheme, India is rapidly translating its capacity creation into deep technological depth, nurturing a vibrant domestic fabless ecosystem that designs the very chips powering the modern world.

The true legacy of this initiative is in the mindset of a nation that now expects innovation, seamless business operations, and governance to be at its fingertips. By ensuring that technology acts as a tool for inclusion, accessibility, and sovereign strength, Digital India is quietly architecting the Viksit Bharat we envision for 2047.

TODAY, INDIA
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SYSTEM

The writer is Secretary of the
Ministry of Electronics and
Information Technology
(MeitY)

India's elderly are ageing faster than its care system can keep up



MURALIDHARA
CP

2ND OPINION

The world is greying quickly, and India is no exception. Global health authorities project that by 2050, one in five people worldwide will be over 60 - twice the share seen in 2015. India already has 157 million people in that age group, one of the largest elderly populations anywhere, and this number will climb to 192 million by 2030. The systems meant to support them - caregiving, healthcare access, social support, and dignity in daily life - are still catching up.

From Family Care to a Vacuum

For generations, Indian families absorbed the responsibility of caring for their elders. That arrangement is unraveling. Urban nuclear families are now the norm in major cities, and adult children working in places like

Bengaluru or Gurugram often cannot provide the sustained, daily care their ageing parents need in cities like Pune or Coimbatore. Families can see the need clearly, but distance, work demands, and shifting household structures make it increasingly difficult to meet.

At the same time, seniors are entering old age with more chronic health conditions than earlier generations faced at the same stage of life. The line between simply growing older and needing real medical support is blurring faster than most communities and families are prepared for.

A Generation That Expects Better

Today's seniors are not passive recipients of whatever care is offered. Many spent their working lives in structured, professional environments, and they carry those expectations into old age - wanting transparency, accountability, and genuine dignity in how they are treated. They ask questions, compare options, and expect real answers. Any system built around old assumptions of quiet compliance is already out of step with this generation.

There's also a practical concern many families overlook: rigid housing commitments don't suit older people well. Committing to a home for retirement, then waiting years for construction to finish, or being unable to leave a community that isn't meeting one's needs, is a poor fit for someone in their 80s who needs flexibility and immediate access to care - not another long-term contract.

What Genuine Care Requires

Meaningful support for India's elderly cannot be reduced to a transaction. It requires daily health monitoring, mobility assistance, medication management, and coordinated medical attention - the kind of sustained, hands-on care that families alone can no longer reliably provide. Trust is everything in this space. Seniors and their families are making decisions about people they love, and failures - in safety, in dignity, in basic responsiveness - are felt immediately and remembered for a long time.

An Undersupplied, Underdiscussed Need

India will need care capacity for well over 5 lakh senior living arrangements by 2030, and what currently exists is fragmented and concentrated in only a few cities. Closing that gap isn't just an infrastructure problem - it's a question of how society chooses to treat its oldest members.

The demographic shift is already locked in. What remains uncertain is whether India builds a system that genuinely serves its ageing population, or one that leaves millions of older people without the care and dignity they need.

Dr. Muralidhara CP, Founder, Jeevin Consulting and Jeevin Senior Care

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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ALLEGATIONS DEMAND A TRANSPARENT INQUIRY

The bribery allegations surrounding the appointment of government advocates by the TVK government, now before the Madras High Court, raise serious concerns about the integrity of public appointments. Government advocates represent the State and safeguard the public interest; any suggestion that such positions were secured through bribery or favouritism undermines confidence in the rule of law.

While the allegations remain subject to judicial scrutiny, the government must respond with transparency rather than treat the matter as a routine political dispute. A government elected on promises of clean governance must demonstrate its commitment through prompt and credible action. An independent inquiry should be instituted

without delay, and the appointments under challenge should remain in abeyance until the investigation is completed.

If irregularities are established, the entire selection process must be reopened through a transparent, merit-based procedure. Such action would protect deserving candidates while restoring public confidence in the system. The Madras High Court's intervention is therefore significant.

Judicial oversight can ensure fairness and adherence to constitutional principles. Ultimately, the issue extends beyond these appointments; it concerns whether public offices are filled through merit or influence. The answer will shape public trust in governance and the administration of justice.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

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MURALI M. MALLAREDDY | VISAKHAPATNAM

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Privacy reforms must not compromise security

Appropos "Govt seeks pause on WhatsApp usernames" (July 2). For years, WhatsApp offered end-to-end encryption but required users to disclose their phone numbers before initiating conversations, exposing an important privacy gap. Meta's decision to introduce unique usernames is therefore a welcome step, enabling users to communicate without revealing personal contact details.

The feature is especially beneficial for professionals, activists and others seeking greater control over their digital identities. However, enhanced privacy must not come at the cost of security. Usernames could also encourage impersonation, fake accounts, username squatting and phishing scams, creating new opportunities for cybercriminals and eroding user trust. The success of this feature will depend on the safeguards accompanying it. Strong identity verification, effective reporting mechanisms, proactive detection of fraudulent accounts and swift action against abuse are essential. Privacy and security are inseparable pillars of the digital ecosystem. While giving users greater control over their identities is a progressive reform, lasting confidence will depend on Meta's ability to ensure authenticity & accountability.

Kerala sets an example in caring for seniors

Kerala has once again demonstrated its leadership in social welfare by creating an exclusive department dedicated to the well-being of senior citizens. As India's ageing population continues to grow, this initiative offers a model that other States should seriously consider adopting.

To maximise its impact, the national helpline for senior citizens, Elderline 14567, must be publicised as extensively as other emergency helpline numbers. Wider awareness will enable elderly citizens facing neglect, abuse or distress to seek timely assistance and access essential support services. Equally important is fostering respect and empathy for senior citizens among younger generations. Awareness about elderly care should begin in schools and colleges through community-based programmes that encourage meaningful interaction between students and senior citizens. Such initiatives can bridge the widening generation gap, promote mutual understanding and preserve the invaluable knowledge and experience of older people.

A compassionate society is judged by the dignity it affords its elderly. Kerala has shown the way; the challenge now is for other States to strengthen institutional support and nurture a culture where senior citizens are valued, protected and actively included in community life.

India and Japan share a common goal

The recent India-Japan Annual Summit has reaffirmed the strength of one of Asia's most trusted strategic partnerships. Expanding cooperation in defence, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, rare earths and economic security reflects the shared resolve of both nations to build resilient supply chains and promote stability in the Indo-Pacific. The partnership also presents enormous economic opportunities. Japan's expertise in advanced technology, precision manufacturing and innovation complements India's large market and skilled workforce. As global businesses seek to diversify supply chains, India is well placed to emerge as a preferred destination for Japanese investment.

To realise this potential, India should establish a dedicated Japan Investment Facilitation Cell to provide sector-specific guidance, expedite clearances and offer strong post-investment support. Greater understanding of Japanese business culture, policy consistency and prompt resolution of operational concerns will further strengthen investor confidence. The next phase of bilateral ties should move towards technology transfer, and advanced manufacturing. A deeper institutional partnership can become a powerful engine of sustainable growth.

Cooperatives: The engine of inclusive growth and sustainable development

From dairy to banking and housing, cooperatives have shaped India’s grassroots economy. As the government pushes the vision of Sahakar Se Samridhhi, modernising these institutions through better governance, technology and professional management can unlock inclusive growth, and build a more resilient economy



SATISH MARATHE

As the world grapples with widening inequalities, climate change, food insecurity, financial instability and the need for sustainable economic growth, the cooperative movement has emerged as one of the most effective models of people-centric development. Cooperatives are not merely business enterprises; they are democratic institutions owned, managed and governed by their members. Built on the principles of self-help, mutual assistance, equality and collective prosperity, cooperatives have consistently demonstrated that economic growth and social justice can go hand in hand.

India has a rich cooperative tradition inspired by visionary leaders such as Mahatma Gandhi, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Acharya Vinoba Bhave, Vaikunthbhai Mehta and Dhananjayrao Gadgil. They viewed cooperation not merely as an economic activity but as a powerful instrument for rural development, social harmony and empowerment of ordinary citizens. Today, as India aspires to become a developed nation by 2047, the cooperative movement is once again acquiring strategic significance in shaping an inclusive and resilient economy.

The cooperative movement in India began with the enactment of the Cooperative Credit Societies Act of 1904. Over the decades, it expanded far beyond agricultural credit to encompass dairy, banking, sugar, fertilisers, housing, fisheries, consumer services, handloom, marketing and numerous other sectors. Today, cooperatives have one of the largest grassroots institutional networks in the country, reaching almost every village and serving millions of members across urban and rural India.

Agriculture continues to provide livelihoods to a substantial proportion of India’s population while supplying raw materials to numerous industries. Small and marginal farmers, who constitute the overwhelming majority of cultivators, often face fragmented landholdings, inadequate access to markets, volatile prices and climate-related uncertainties. Cooperatives provide an institutional mechanism through which these farmers can pool resources, access affordable credit, procure quality inputs, undertake collective marketing and strengthen their bargaining power.

Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS), dairy cooperatives and farmer producer organisations have become indispensable pillars of rural development. Beyond credit delivery, modern cooperatives are increasingly participating in food processing, warehousing, value addition, cold storage and exports, enabling farmers to capture a larger share of the value chain. This transformation is particularly significant at a time when global food demand continues to rise and agricultural sustainability has become a worldwide concern.

The Government of India’s decision to establish a dedicated Ministry of Cooperation under the vision of “Sahakar Se Samridhhi” marks an important milestone in revitalising the sector. The computerisation of PACS, expansion of multipurpose cooperative societies, creation of a national cooperative database, promotion of cooperative exports and initiatives for the world’s largest grain storage programme through cooperatives reflect a renewed policy commitment to strengthening grassroots institutions. The cooperative model is equally significant in financial inclusion. Cooperative banks and credit societies have historically extended banking services to areas where commercial banks found limited commercial viability. By mobilising local savings and providing affordable credit, they have supported agriculture, micro-enterprises, artisans, self-employed workers and rural entrepreneurs. Unlike purely profit-driven financial institutions, cooperatives operate on the principle of member welfare, ensuring that financial services remain accessible to economically weaker sections.

Housing cooperatives have enabled millions of middle-class families to own affordable homes, while consumer cooperatives have protected members from exploitative market practices. Dairy cooperatives have transformed India into one of the world’s largest milk producers, demonstrating how collective ownership can create globally competitive enterprises. Despite these achievements, the Indian cooperative sector faces several structural challenges. Many societies suffer from dormant membership, inadequate member participation, weak governance, political interference, insufficient professional man-



agement and excessive dependence on government financial support. Financial stress arising from loan defaults, limited capital mobilisation and inadequate technological adoption has also affected the competitiveness of several cooperative institutions.

Addressing these challenges requires comprehensive reforms rather than greater governmental control. Cooperative autonomy, democratic functioning, professional management, transparent governance and accountability must remain the cornerstones of future reforms. Legislative frameworks should facilitate innovation while preserving the unique identity of cooperatives as member-owned enterprises.

The constitutional recognition accorded to cooperatives through the Ninety-Seventh Constitutional Amendment reinforced the importance of voluntary formation, democratic control and autonomous functioning. Although constitutional developments have refined its scope, the amendment remains an important milestone in recognising cooperatives as essential institutions of democratic economic development. Globally, the cooperative movement represents one of the largest socio-economic networks in the world. More than one billion people across over one hundred countries are members of cooperatives operating in diverse sectors including agriculture, finance, insurance, healthcare, retail, housing, fisheries, renewable energy and telecommunications. Millions of jobs worldwide are directly or indirectly supported by cooperative enterprises.

Countries such as Finland, Canada, New Zealand, Singapore and Norway demonstrate exceptionally high levels of cooperative participation. Kenya derives a significant share of its GDP from cooperative enterprises, while New Zealand’s dairy industry owes much of its global competitiveness to farmer-owned cooperatives. Cooperative banks in Europe have consistently demonstrated financial resilience, often weathering global financial crises more effectively than investor-owned institutions because of their prudent lending practices and long-term orientation. Health cooperatives have become important providers of affordable healthcare in countries such as Brazil, Japan, France, Germany and the Netherlands. Consumer cooperatives dominate retail markets in Switzerland, Italy and Singapore, while housing cooperatives have successfully addressed urban housing challenges in Scandinavia, the United Kingdom and the United States. Electricity cooperatives continue to deliver reliable power to rural communities in the United States, Bangladesh and Argentina where private utilities have limited commercial incentives to operate. International experience also demonstrates the remarkable resilience of cooperatives during periods of conflict and economic disruption. In countries recovering from civil wars, cooperatives have helped rebuild livelihoods, restore agricultural production, revive financial systems and strengthen community trust. Their democratic character enables them to bridge social

divisions and foster inclusive local development.

However, cooperatives worldwide face emerging challenges. Rapid technological change, digital transformation, climate risks, changing consumer behaviour, cybersecurity concerns and increasing competition from multinational corporations require cooperative institutions to modernise their operations. Attracting young professionals, promoting women’s leadership and embracing digital governance have become essential for ensuring long-term sustainability.

Climate change presents both a challenge and an opportunity. Cooperatives are uniquely positioned to promote climate-resilient agriculture, renewable energy, water conservation, organic farming, sustainable fisheries and community-based natural resource management. Their local ownership structure enables them to implement environmentally responsible practices while ensuring that economic benefits remain within local communities.

Digital technology offers another transformative opportunity. Integration with digital payments, e-commerce platforms, artificial intelligence, precision agriculture, blockchain-enabled supply chains and digital marketplaces can significantly enhance transparency, efficiency and market access. Cooperatives that successfully combine traditional community values with modern technology will be well positioned to compete in an increasingly digital economy.

The future of India’s cooperative movement lies in creating professionally managed, technologically enabled and globally competitive institutions that remain firmly rooted in democratic values. Greater emphasis on skill development, financial literacy, innovation, entrepreneurship and cooperative education will help create a new generation of capable cooperative leaders.

As India advances towards becoming a developed economy, cooperatives can serve as powerful engines of inclusive growth by reducing inequalities, empowering farmers, generating employment, strengthening rural industries, promoting women’s economic participation and ensuring equitable distribution of wealth. They represent an economic model where prosperity is created through collective participation.

The cooperative movement may not be the sole answer to every developmental challenge, but it undoubtedly constitutes one of the most effective pathways towards sustainable and inclusive progress. By combining economic efficiency with social responsibility and democratic governance, cooperatives embody the vision of development that leaves no one behind. Strengthened by progressive policies, modern technology and active member participation, India’s cooperative sector can become a defining pillar of national development, transforming the philosophy of “Sahakar Se Samridhhi” into a lasting reality for millions of citizens.

The writer is a founder member of Sahakar Bharti, Director Central Board RBI, NABARD & NHB

The spotless kingdom: What the ‘clean’ countries conceal



ACHARYA PRASHANT

I have been travelling through Britain these past weeks, speaking at Cambridge, at Oxford, and in the British Parliament on freedom, self-knowledge, and the climate crisis. Last Friday evening, at the London School of Economics, I sat in dialogue with Professor Jonathan Birch on animal sentience. Professor Birch’s research informed recent animal welfare legislation, and in matters of animal protection, Britain is counted among the leading nations of the world.

That same evening, I went to Richmond Park, the great royal park on the edge of London. Dusk was settling. Deer grazed on the open grass without a trace of fear; rabbits darted out of the undergrowth. At first sight the park seems to announce something admirable about the society that maintains it. Look, it says, how free these animals are, how protected! Then I learned that every year, roughly two hundred deer are killed in this very park, methodically, as a matter of policy. Richmond Park was enclosed in 1637 by Charles I as a hunting ground, and the deer were brought in for exactly that purpose. They are not native to this ground; they were imported for royal ‘sport’. The centuries passed, the hunting stopped, but the deer remained inside the same walls. Now, when their numbers grow, the growth is described as a problem, and the killing is described as management. First, uproot an animal from its habitat and settle it elsewhere for your entertainment. Next, declare the settlement you created to be an ecological problem, and offer killing as its solution. The killing itself is conducted at night, in silence, so that no visitor strolling through the park the next morning has the faintest idea of what happened there in the dark.

The park photographs beautifully, and that is precisely what should give one pause. A scene can look clean for two very different reasons: because the dirt has been removed, or because the dirt has been hidden. What the park and its deer communicate is not love of animals but the performance of it. Real affection for these creatures would never have tolerated the arrangement in the first place: brought here for slaughter, kept here for display, killed here for convenience. The welfare legislation is real, the research behind it is rigorous, and the killing continues regardless.

The developed world speaks a particular vocabulary: clean energy, clean technology, clean growth. Listen to this vocabulary carefully, because it contains a confession its speakers did not intend to make.

The moment a technology is called ‘clean’ because it emits less carbon, a definition has been established. Cleanliness now means low carbon; dirt now means high carbon. That definition did not come from the Global South; it was authored and institutionalised by the developed nations themselves. Very well then; let the definition be applied consistently. If it holds for a machine, it must also hold for the society that runs the machine. Apply it, and the world’s moral geography rearranges itself. The global average for per-capita carbon emissions stands at roughly 4.9 tonnes a year. Saudi Arabia sits near 22.8 tonnes, Australia at 22.3, Canada at 19.8, Russia at 18, the United States at 17.3. India’s figure is about two tonnes per person, among the lowest of any major economy on earth, and that figure belongs to a country carrying a fifth of humanity. By the developed world’s own chosen metric, the country so long dismissed as unclean stands in the front rank of the world’s clean nations.

A clarification is necessary here. Nothing said so far is an indictment of any particular people, because the tendency being described is universal, and India supplies its own evidence. Watch an Indian abroad. The same person who tosses litter onto his own street without a second thought becomes, in London or Singapore, a scrupulous follower of every rule. He queues, sorts his rubbish, waits for the signal. His nationality has not changed between the two cities; his circumstances have. The change came from outside pressure rather than inner intent: from fear of fines, from surveillance, from the social shame of being seen.

Remove the pressure and the old habit walks straight back in. So the matter was never one of nation or race; it is one of circumstance, and beneath circumstance, of the ego, which bows readily to external pressure while remaining untouched within. The fine, the camera, and the disapproving glance can all discipline behaviour; none of them has ever reached the one behaving. That is why the discipline travels so poorly, evaporating the moment the enforcement does. So the real question was never whether the cleanliness exists. Anyone can see that it exists; the lawns of London are proof enough. The question is what the cleanliness proceeds from. Cleanliness born of fear departs when the fear departs, and the kind born of law breaks wherever the law cannot see. As for the cleanliness maintained for display, it does not remove dirt at all; it relocates dirt to wherever the audience isn’t looking, which is exactly what the emissions data and the nighttime culls of Richmond Park describe in their different vocabularies. Had there been real love of cleanliness, the response to dirt would have been its removal rather than its concealment.

The industry’s demand would have been reduced rather than its address changed. The deer would never have needed the darkness. Every one of these arrangements testifies to the same thing, which is that the claim of love remains, so far, a performance of love. So what, then, does real cleanliness actually mean? The ego is the performer. The ego is the dirt within, and the same ego is what dirties the world without; a polluted interior can polish its exterior endlessly and produce nothing except dirt with a better complexion. That evening in Richmond Park stays with me. Somewhere in the coming months, on some scheduled night, about two hundred deer will quietly cease to exist, and the morning visitors will notice nothing. If carbon dioxide ever acquires a colour, the world will discover where its real dirt has been accumulating all along. Until then, the question stands open: who will render the true account of the developed world’s cleanliness?

Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life.



Ancient Indian thoughts on Intelligence for internal security



NEHA G

Over two millennia ago, long before the digital age of encryption and satellite surveillance, the foundations of sophisticated intelligence systems were laid in ancient India. From Kautilya’s clinical analysis in the Arthashastra to the pragmatic diplomacy of Tiruvalluvar’s Tirukkural, statecraft was viewed as a rigorous science in which information served as a vital instrument of power. These ancient texts discuss espionage, diplomacy, and governance in ways that continue to resonate in the modern era of strategic competition and information warfare.

Kautilya in his Arthashastra described a sophisticated intelligence system comparable to a modern secret service, a crucial instrument of power. Secret agents (gudha purusa) were broadly divided into stationary and mobile spies. While stationary agents reported to the ruler’s chancellor, the most sensitive intelligence operations were directly supervised by the ruler himself. These stationary agents included civil servants who did routine surveillance, ascetics with religious covers, spies posing as astrologers, bankrupt farmers, artisans and merchants who monitored neighbours and customers, among others. Mobile agents, i.e. intel-

lectually sharp female agents who infiltrated wealthy homes, artists and servants who used poison to kill, assisted elite intelligence officers reporting to the ruler personally. Espionage was directed not only against enemy states but also against ally and neutral states, for example, placing secret informants at their courts.

Hence, detailed categories of people encompassing nearly all social groups operated in various locations as spies to avoid suspicion, including children when necessary. This vast network of secret agents and informants collected information about treasonable activities, corruption, serious crime, popular mood and acted as ‘secret police’. Kautilya advocates techniques such as, secret agents infiltrating enemy camps to spread disinformation often as “divine proclamations” to create fragmentation within the enemy’s hierarchy or to declare fictitious triumphs to inspire their own troops, using deception to propagate disunity amongst internal rivals by inducing a ruler’s second or third son to attempt a revolution against their own family, tracing and unmasking of enemy agents, turning exposed enemy agents into double agents rather than discharging them, employing trained killers for covert assassinations and extra-judicial killings disguised as accident, normal crime, or natural death and staging political public relations to influence public opinion.

If the secret service detects legitimate public grievances or growing anger among sections of the population, Kautilya argues that the state must first address their root causes before resorting to



repression. Arthashastra looks at the ruler’s duty to secure and expand public welfare as inseparable from the strength of the state. The secret service therefore functions not merely as an instrument of surveillance, but as an “early warning system” that alerts the ruler to social discontent and policy failures, enabling timely corrective action. Kautilya also insists that statecraft must rest on empirical data and scientific knowledge grounded in reality, rejecting magic, astrology, prophecy, or impulse. He further considers a strong economic base essential to internal stability and security. Enhancing agriculture, production, trade and tax revenue was therefore central to state power. He warns that a weak state leads to matsya-nyaya, the “law of the fishes,” where the strong prey upon the weak, both within society

and in inter-state relations.

The Arthashastra has discussed four methods of statecraft (upayas) that predate it within the Indian traditional wisdom, in the order: saam (peaceful conciliation), daam (enticement or bribery), dand (force or punishment), bhed (division or sowing discord) for diplomatic relations. The Tirukkural (Kural) by Tiruvalluvar also considers diplomacy essential to maintaining stable inter-state relations. Tiruvalluvar emphasises that ministers and ambassadors must be skilled in statecraft, knowledgeable about world affairs, and capable of making prompt and impartial decisions. He also highlights the importance of persuasive and fearless communication in foreign courts. In matters of diplomacy, the Kural often adopts a pragmatic approach, advising rulers to reconcile with stronger powers while acting firmly against weaker adversaries.

Echoing the Kautilyan principle of dvaidhibhav (dual policy), Verse 875 advises that a ruler helpless against two foes should secure one as an ally to help against the other. Verse 679 further suggests to secure alliances with the enemies of one’s enemies than to focus solely on existing friends.

Kautilya’s views on intelligence encompass more than just information collection and analysis, but also counterintelligence, i.e. manipulating the espionage picture of one’s own state for the enemy in one’s favour. He prioritises covert means such as subversion, sabotage and targeted operations over conventional wars that cause great human and material losses. Kautilya may seldom be cited explicitly in India’s strate-

gic discourse, but his influence remains deeply embedded. Mahatma Gandhi’s preference for non-violent resistance can be seen through a Kautilyan lens of realism, choosing methods that weaken a stronger adversary without incurring unsustainable costs like a traditional war.

Kamandaka’s Nitisara (Nitishastra) also advises against frequent warfare due to its destructive consequences. At the same time, he stresses the importance of safeguarding state secrets while systematically probing an adversary’s vulnerabilities, an early articulation of what is today called information asymmetry. His intelligence framework is broad, extending even to monitoring weather, disasters and epidemics that could affect state stability.

The relevance of these ideas has remained unaltered through the ages. Intelligence agencies today continue to strive hard as agents not only of security but of strategic foresight – anticipating and preempting threats, preventing mishaps, shaping outcomes and protecting the nation from all kinds of threats – internal and external. Ancient Indian wisdom reveals that internal security was never viewed merely in terms of coercion or military strength, but rather as dependent upon informed governance, economic resilience, effective diplomacy and responsiveness to public grievances. In an age increasingly shaped by covert influence and hybrid threats, the above principles of intelligence continue to hold good for all times to come.

The writer is Junior Research Fellow, Bharat Ki Soch

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Order Order

SCBA condemns threats against MP district judge



The Supreme Court Bar Association on Friday condemned alleged threats, abusive social media campaign and acts of intimidation directed against Additional District and Sessions Judge Tabassum Khan following her judgment sentencing members of a cow vigilante group in a lynching case.

"The Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) expects the High Court of Madhya Pradesh and the government of Madhya Pradesh to ensure a prompt, fair and effective investigation into the matter, identify all those responsible for issuing threats or inciting hatred against the judicial officer, and take strict action against them in accordance with law," the bar body said in a statement issued by its secretary Pragya Baghel.

The bar body said reports indicated that the judicial officer was subjected to threats and online abuse after pronouncing a verdict in a criminal case, resulting in the registration of an FIR and the enhancement of her security.

"The district judiciary is the foundation of our justice delivery system. Judicial officers across the country decide thousands of sensitive civil and criminal cases every day. They deserve the assurance that the law will protect them whenever they faithfully discharge their constitutional responsibilities," it said.

The statement said the SCBA stood firmly in support of the judge and reiterated its unwavering commitment to safeguarding the independence, dignity and impartiality of the judiciary.

(PTI)

Hearing on Khan Sir's bail plea deferred till July 7



A Patna court on Thursday deferred the hearing of educator Faisal Khan, popularly known as 'Khan Sir', anticipatory bail plea in connection with the coaching institute firing case till July 7.

The case relates to a firing incident that occurred in early June after Khan Sir's coaching institute was allegedly vandalised by a group of miscreants. His security guards are accused of opening fire during the incident.

The court was also expected to hear the bail applications of both security guards of Khan Sir who are in judicial custody.

"Since the district judge was absent today, the hearing took place under ADJ-2. The next hearing will take place on July 7," educator Roshan Anand's advocate Satyam Jha told PTI Video.

Reiterating the same facts, Khan Sir's advocate Arvind Kumar Mouar added that the "stay on Khan Sir's arrest has been extended till July 7."

Both the advocates said that the hearing on the bail petitions of Khan Sir's two bodyguards will also take place on the same date.

(PTI)

Mamata, Abhishek told to file affidavits in contempt petition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Friday directed Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee and general secretary Abhishek Banerjee to file affidavits in a contempt petition alleging violation of the court's direction on blocking arterial roads during the party's July 21 Martyrs' Day rally in 2025.

The petitioner alleged contempt of the high court's order passed in May, 2018, which had directed that public meetings or gatherings on thoroughfares must not cause total blockage of the road.

A division bench presided by Justice Arijit Banerjee directed Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee to file affidavits within the next four weeks stating their position over the allegation in the contempt petition.

The court directed the



petitioner to file his affidavit in reply to the contention of the TMC leaders within the subsequent two weeks.

The division bench, also comprising Justice Apurba Sinha Ray, directed that the matter will appear for next hearing on August 17.

A division bench comprising the then Chief Justice Jyotirmoy Bhattacharya and Justice Arijit Banerjee had in 2018 directed that passage must be left on such roads for the movement of pedestrians and emergency vehicles.



SC recognises homemakers as nation builders



ARUN
BHARDWAJ

In 1917, Mahatma Gandhi had said: "Women are the companion of man, gifted with equal mental capacities, she has the right to participate in the minutest details in the activities of man, and she has an equal right of freedom and liberty with him." Since independence, there has hardly been any judgment that has dealt with, or examined the contribution of women in family life, nation building, and the economy. Though, primarily because of votes, from time to time, various political parties have been announcing schemes which appear to be beneficial for women.

In a recent judgment dated 11.06.2026, in the matter of Shishu Pal Vs Surjeet & Ors, a Bench of the Supreme Court of India comprising Justice Sanjay Karol and Justice N Kotiswar Singh, in a landmark judgment, dealt with several burning issues pertaining to the dispensation of justice in Motor Accident Cases and delays therein. While adjudicating the issues, the Supreme Court also recognised the contribution of women in "Home Making" and "Nation Building" and the contribution estimated at 15-17 per cent to the GDP by unpaid care giving work/household/unrecognised work.

Peculiar facts of the case were that in November, 2001, a lady/house wife died in a road accident. In December, 2003, the Motor Accident Claim Tribunal granted a meagre compensation of ₹2,42,000 only. Being aggrieved, the family



members of the deceased filed an appeal in 2004, which was allowed by the High Court in December 2024 (after a delay of 21 years), enhancing the compensation to ₹8,43,000 along with interest at 7.5 per cent from the date of filing of the petition. It was further ordered that in case the amount is not paid within 3 months, then the rate of interest would be further enhanced to 9 per cent per annum and further, in case the amount is not paid within the said period, then the rate of interest would be enhanced to 12 per cent per annum.

Not satisfied, the family members of the deceased challenged the same before the Supreme Court in 2025. The fact that the appeal before the High Court was filed in 2004 and was decided at the fag end of 2024, the Supreme Court called for the record of the appeal to find out the cause of delay. The High Court record shows that in the year 2011, a fire broke out, in which

the original record of several files got burnt and the High Court removed about 2200 cases from the list of pending cases as their files could not be reconstructed. It took almost 14 years for the reconstruction of Shishu Pal Vs. Surjeet & Ors. file. The Supreme Court took serious note of the situation that in the cases arising out of either an injury or death, the circumstances are different and beneficiary-oriented litigation in such cases should not be pending at the level of the High Court for a period of 4 years. Keeping these circumstances in mind, a bench comprising Justice Sanjay Karol had adjudicated over 100 appeals in beneficiary-oriented cases wef 11.02.2025 to 20.04.2026. In almost 50 per cent of the matters, the pendencies were over 4 years.

The Bench expressed its unhappiness over the picture of pendency and held that "in reality, the households functioning depends

substantially on the homemaker. The earning members are in fact solely dependent on the homemaker but alas, the reality does not receive the acknowledgement it deserves." The Bench took note of the recommendation issued in the tenth session of the Committee of Elimination of Discrimination against Women, wherein the quantification of the unremunerated domestic activities of women, which contribute to development in each country, reveals the de facto economic role of women. The contribution of women in home-making and Nation Building has been judicially pronounced by the Supreme Court.

In Lata Wadhwa Case (2001) 8 SCC 197, the Supreme Court had calculated compensation using the ₹3,000 per month metric. However, in Shishu Pal Case the Supreme court held that not justifiable and observed that "to measure the contributions of a

homemaker and mother as in this case in strictly Monetary Terms is a task of considerable difficulty for each and every aspect of the day, month and year of such homemaker family member is informed, shaped by her sometimes acknowledge, but most often unacknowledged or taken for granted." While discussing other case laws and in view of the peculiar facts of the Shishu Pal Case, the Supreme Court computed "loss of domestic care/ monthly income at ₹30,000 and keeping other factor such as, future prospects, multiplier deduction etc awarded the compensation of ₹62,77,900.

While concluding, in order to take care of delays at the Tribunal and High Court level, the Supreme Court directed that Claim Petitions shall be accompanied by necessary proofs such as: (i) Official proof, date of birth, (ii) Disability certificate as also the opinion of the doctor regarding functional disability, (iii) ITR/ Salary Slips issued by the employer under stamp and the seal/ certificate of salary issued by the employer under the stamp and seal, (iv) If compensation is claimed under the head of medical expenses, bills duly attested by the competent authority of the clinic/hospital/nursing homes be attached, (v) If attendant charges are claimed and such a person is already in employment, a notarised affidavit, disclosing salary paid to them, per month.

This judgment will go a long way in curtailing delays in Motor Accident Claims.

The writer is a senior advocate

NCLT reserves order on Sapphire Land Development liquidation plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has reserved its order on a petition seeking liquidation of Sapphire Land Development, triggering debate in insolvency circles over whether a company can be liquidated without completing a mandatory procedural requirement under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

The case has spotlighted a critical gap in the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP): the non-publication of Form G, the official invitation for Expressions of Interest (EOIs) from prospective resolution applicants. During the hearing, the Resolution Professional informed the tribunal that the statutory CIRP timeline had expired.

Form G was never published because the Committee of Creditors (CoC) did not approve its issuance. Suraksha Asset Reconstruction Ltd., which moved the liquidation plea, argued that the process had effectively run its course, with significant CIRP costs already incurred and no realistic chance of a successful resolution. However, Unity Small Finance Bank strongly opposed the plea, contending that the CIRP remained incomplete. The bank pointed out that Regulation 36A of the CIRP



Regulations mandates the publication of Form G to invite potential resolution applicants. In its absence, no opportunity was given to investors or bidders to submit resolution plans.

The lender further submitted that while the proposal to publish Form G was placed before the CoC, the voting process was never concluded, preventing the process from advancing to the stage of inviting, evaluating, and considering competing resolution plans. The development has raised a broader legal question: Can a corporate debtor be pushed into liquidation when a core step designed to test market interest in its revival has not been undertaken? Insolvency professionals emphasise that Form G is not a mere formality but the primary mechanism to expose distressed assets to the market and attract potential rescuers.

Skipping it, they argue, undermines the IBC's core objective of prioritising resolution over liquidation.

Legal experts are watching the NCLT's forthcoming order closely. It could set a precedent on how tribunals should handle cases involving incomplete procedural steps. Possible outcomes include directing the completion of the remaining CIRP formalities before considering liquidation, or ruling that the expiry of the statutory timeline overrides the procedural lapse.

Any liquidation order is likely to be challenged before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), where issues concerning compliance with Regulation 36A and the IBC's preference for resolution are expected to come under judicial scrutiny.

The tribunal has reserved its order, with the decision awaited in the coming days.

Acquisition of place of worship for secular purposes not barred: HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has observed that the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991 prohibits only the 'conversion' of the religious character of a place of worship from one religious denomination to another, but it does not bar the state from acquiring such properties for secular and public purposes.

The court dismissed a writ petition seeking to halt the widening and beautification of the Dalmandi area in Varanasi, a project undertaken as a part of the Uttar Pradesh government's Shri Kashi Vishwanath Dham corridor development.

The petitioners, who are six tenants and shopkeepers operating in the Dalmandi area, moved the high court seeking a writ of mandamus to prevent their dispossession from the area. They also sought protection for six ancient mosques in the area that were proposed for takeover and demolition as part of the project.

Dismissing the writ petition filed by Syed Rashid Ali and six other tenants, a division bench comprising Justices JJ Munir and Arun Kumar observed, "The Act of 1991 prohibits the conver-



sion of place of worship of one religious denomination into another. It does not derogate from the state's authority to acquire any place of religious worship for a secular and public purpose like development of a road or augmentation of infrastructure or any similar activity."

The Dalmandi area is located around 800 metres from the Kashi Vishwanath temple and the six ancient mosques proposed for demolition by the administration are Anjuman Intezamia Masjid, Masjid Rangile Shah, Masjid Ali Raza Khan, Masjid Karimullah Baig, Masjid Nisaran and Masjid Sangamarmar.

In its 32-page judgment delivered on Thursday, the court observed that the petitioners being mere tenants and not owners of the properties in question had limited standing to challenge the acquisition process.

"We would think that the petitioners are more or less here in order to protect their business and source of livelihood rather than proprietary rights," it noted.

The court further noted that the title holders had not come forward to challenge the project emphasising that in matters of land acquisition under the 2013 Act, it is primarily the title holder who has locus to object, negotiate a sale or suffer an acquisition.

The court also was not persuaded that being Muslims, the petitioners themselves have a right to protect the mosques in question. On this, the court said, "The mosques are admittedly registered Waqf with their own Mutawalli in each case. No doubt, members of the Muslim community may come forward in certain cases, but essentially it is the Mutawalli and the Waqf Board who have to protect such properties."

SC refuses to stay bail to Sonam Raghuvanshi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday refused to stay a Meghalaya High Court order granting bail to Sonam Raghuvanshi, accused of killing her husband during their honeymoon in the north eastern state in 2025.

A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and Sheel Nagu expressed reservation over the high court order but refused to stay it, noting that Raghuvanshi has been released from jail and is in Shillong pursuant to the bail conditions imposed by the trial court. Appearing in the court for the State, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta said the allegations against Raghuvanshi are serious in nature and she cannot be released on technical grounds. Mehta said the case is "really shocking" and sought a stay of the high court order granting bail as it was given citing non-supply of full grounds of arrest.

"This is the case where both of them went on honeymoon in Meghalaya. It



was a premeditated murder. There were three of her accomplices. She killed the husband on a hill and threw the dead body into a gorge. The three assailants and the lady herself were part of the physical assault. She absconded and was later arrested from a place in Uttar Pradesh," Mehta said.

If the high court order is not stayed, she may abscond, he said and referred to the order of the magistrate, who issued the order for transit remand in Uttar Pradesh and had recorded satisfaction that the grounds of arrest were supplied to her. Mehta submitted that multiple bail applications of Raghuvanshi

have been rejected and the ground of non-supply of documents was not taken in any of those. He said it was a typographical error to refer to section 403(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) instead of section 103(1) (punishment for murder) and the high court upheld the grant of bail on this ground.

When the bench asked about the stage of the trial, Mehta said the trial is going on, adding that of the 94 witnesses, four have been examined. The bench told the counsel, appearing for Raghuvanshi, "Prima facie, we have some reservation with the high court's judgment. The way the high court

has dealt with the issue, we have a reservation with that."

Justice Sundresh pointed out that the grounds of arrest were explained to Raghuvanshi and it was recorded in the magistrate's order, and this ground was not raised in the previous bail applications.

"After that, somehow, the wisdom dawned on you and you raised this ground. Is the court right in granting bail on the technical ground that a wrong provision was quoted, especially when bail was rejected on merits earlier?" Justice Sundresh asked. The lawyer, however, claimed that the grounds of arrest were never communicated to Raghuvanshi at any point. He submitted that the magistrate's order was for transit remand, when she was not represented by her counsel and only a memo was given to her.

Justice Sundresh asked if that is the case, could this ground be raised belatedly.

"If bail is granted only on this reason, the State is not barred under the law from arresting her again," the

bench said. The accused's counsel then submitted that she has been put to strict bail conditions by the trial court and has to remain in Shillong itself, and hence, there is no likelihood of her absconding.

The bench then noted that the accused has already been released and expressed its reluctance to stay the bail order. "If she is released, then we cannot stay the order," it said, adding that the court was under the impression that she was still under custody.

The solicitor general then attempted to persuade the bench by highlighting the gravity of the crime. He said instances of wives killing husbands are increasing and referred to the recent Lohagad case, where a woman allegedly killed her fiancé. Justice Sundresh said an element of introspection is needed from all stakeholders and referred to another case from Bengaluru.

The Meghalaya government moved the Supreme Court on Thursday against the bail granted to the prime accused in the case.

details and for downloading the tender documents. Please visit website at <http://www.irens.gov.in>

▼PROSPECT

CBI books ex-STC CMD, 6 former officials, KS Oils

The CBI has registered an FIR against former State Trading Corporation CMD, six ex-officials and KS Oils Ltd over alleged irregularities in extending ₹75 crore in trade finance for mustard oil purchases between 2010 and 2014, officials said on Friday. The CBI has alleged that STC extended trade finance to KSOL without proper due diligence, issued Letters of Credit (LC) beyond the approved limit, shell and front companies were used as suppliers of mustard oil and LC proceeds were routed back to the company, according to the FIR. The agency said in the FIR – registered after over a year of preliminary enquiry – that a false storage quality certification was issued and timely recovery action was not taken, causing wrongful loss to STC and corresponding wrongful gain to the accused persons and entities. KSOL Chairman Ramesh Chand Garg and Director Daves Aggarwal had approached STC for trade finance for the purchase of mustard oil, it said.

Lakhipur’s Kew Pineapple enters Dubai market



Renowned for its exceptional sweetness and organic quality, Lakhipur Pineapple has already made its way to Dubai, bringing global recognition to the hard work and dedication of our farmers. The Kew variety of pineapple grown in Lakhipur is among the finest varieties in India and stands as a testament to the region’s rich agricultural potential.

This initiative will strengthen post-harvest management, enhance market linkages and create greater opportunities for our pineapple growers. We remain committed to empowering our farmers and unlocking the full potential of Cachar’s world-class pineapple. The programme was graced by Rahul Gupta, DC Cachar, Sandeep Saha, Regional Head (NER & Ladakh), Dhruvajyoti Pathak, CDC, Lakhipur, Raktim Baruah, ADC, Cachar, Pijush Rai, Assistant Commissioner, Cachar, Dr Sunil Pareek, Professor & Dean, NIFTEM, Evan T Munsong, DGM, NABARD, Dr Rahul Chakraborty, District Agriculture Officer, Reena Singh, Chairman, All Manipuri Development Council, and Mirinal Kanti Das, Chairman Lakhipur MB.

MOC launches new cancer care centre in Faridabad

The Mumbai Oncocare Centre (MOC) has inaugurated a new facility in Faridabad, expanding its presence in North India and strengthening access to specialised cancer services across NCR. The facility was inaugurated by Dr YK Gupta, President, AIIMS Kalyani, West Bengal and Principal Advisor India Strategy Development – Global Antibiotics Research and Development Partnership. This centre is the 31st cancer centre by MOC. MOC has impacted the lives of over five lakh cancer patients and administers more than 85,000 chemotherapy treatments annually. The Faridabad centre adds to the organisation’s footprint aimed at making specialised oncology care more accessible and affordable.

ED auctions seized business jet for ₹3 crore in Ponzi case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Friday said it has auctioned a seized business plane for ₹3 crore as part of a money laundering investigation against a Hyderabad-based company and its promoters on charges of duping investors through a multi-crore Ponzi scheme.

The Hawker 800A aircraft, parked at the Rajeev Gandhi International Airport at Shamshabad in Telangana’s capital city, was seized by the central agency’s Hyderabad zonal office in March 2025 during searches in the case against the company named Capital Protection Force Pvt Ltd.

The ED subsequently moved an application before the Adjudicating Authority of the Prevention of Money Laundering (Taking possession of attached or frozen properties confirmed by the Adjudicating Authority) Rules, 2013, seeking permission to sell the seized aircraft, the agency said in a statement.

The adjudicating authority allowed the ED to auction the seized aircraft in November 2025, it said.

The plane was auctioned through Metal Scrap Trade



ED team auctions jet

Corporation Ltd (MSTC) on July 1 for a sale consideration of ₹3 crore, according to the ED.

This money shall be utilised by the ED for restitution to the genuine investors in accordance with the provisions of the PMLA, subject to the leave of the Special Court established under the anti-money laundering law,

it said. The money laundering case stems from an FIR filed by the EOW of Cyberabad Police against Capital Protection Force Pvt Ltd. (Falcon Group), its CMD Amardeep Kumar and some others.

It was alleged that the accused “defrauded” a large number of investors through a Ponzi scheme to the tune of ₹792 crore on the pretext of returning a higher amount to the investors that was received under an invoice discounting scheme, though no such actual business was carried out.

The agency had arrested three persons in this case, including Kumar’s brother Sandeep Kumar, Chartered Accountant Sharad Chandra Toshniwal and CEO of Falcon Invoice Discounting Aryan Singh Chhabra. It also filed a charge sheet in this case in September last year.

Red Shield Division conducts security conference under military-civil fusion initiative



TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

As part of the ongoing Military-Civil Fusion initiative, the Red Shield Division under the aegis of Spear Corps organised a Security Conference at Laipul on July 1, 2026, in preparation for the forthcoming Independence Day celebrations. The conference was aimed at strengthening inter-agency coordination and reviewing the overall security framework to ensure the peaceful and secure conduct of Independence Day.

The conference was attended by Army officials and representatives of the Assam Police, including the

SSP, Tinsukia and Dibrugarh.

Deliberations focused on intelligence sharing, coordinated preventive measures, proactive security planning and enhanced inter-agency synergy to effectively address emerging security challenges.

The conference concluded with all stakeholders reaffirming their commitment to seamless coordination and a unified approach towards ensuring a safe, secure and incident-free Independence Day. Through such collaborative initiatives, the Indian Army continues to strengthen military-civil fusion, foster mutual trust with civil agencies and contribute towards maintaining peace, security and stability in the region.

Tata Power-DDL secures 7 convictions in electricity theft cases in FY 2026-27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To combat the issue of power theft and ensure disciplined electricity usage, Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (Tata Power-DDL) has secured 7 convictions in electricity theft cases so far in FY 2026-27, including the recent conviction from Patiala House Courts. The special court has sentenced the offender to undergo one month of rigorous imprisonment and a fine of ₹10,000, along with civil liability of ₹379,124/-.

The case pertains to an electricity theft complaint received by Tata Power-DDL’s Corporate Enforcement Group, following which an inspection was conducted on February 17, 2023, at an unauthorised jhuggi located opposite WZ-462, near the Pump House, Village Todapur, Dasghara, Delhi.

During the inspection, Devi Prasan, son of Raj Kumar, originally a resident of Haryana, was found dishonestly abstracting electricity for domestic use by



directly tapping the LT Network Distribution Box through illegal wires connected to the premises. The enforcement team assessed a connected load of 7.408 kW, with electricity being illegally used for domestic purposes, including the operation of multiple electrical appliances, commercial use of a concrete mixer machine, and charging of e-rickshaws. The theft assessment was calculated at ₹379,124/-. The inspection proceedings were documented through photographs and videography, while the illegal wires used for theft were removed and seized as evidence.

After examining the inspection report, seizure memo, site plan, photographs, videographic evidence and testimonies of the enforcement team, the Court of Syed Zishan Ali Warsi, Additional Sessions Judge, Patiala House Courts, found Devi Prasan guilty of power theft punishable under Sections 135 and 150 of the Electricity Act, 2003, and sentenced him to one month of rigorous imprisonment with a fine of ₹10,000. He was further held liable to pay civil liability of ₹379,124/- under Section 154(5) of the Electricity Act for using electricity illegally.

The conviction reinforces

Tata Power-DDL’s continued efforts to curb electricity theft through regular enforcement drives and sustained legal action while sending a strong message that power theft is a punishable offence carrying both criminal and financial consequences.

Commenting on the development, spokesperson, Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited, said, “Such judgements help reinforce disciplined usage of electricity in Delhi. This conviction further strengthens our resolve to eradicate the menace of power theft from our area of operations. We continue to appeal to consumers to avoid unethical practices and act as responsible consumers.”

Beyond ensuring a reliable power supply, these actions reflect Tata Power-DDL’s focus on providing sustainable and affordable electricity, supporting community development, and strengthening customer experience through continuous engagement and a nuanced understanding of customer needs.

ACE India, KATO Japan join hands for global market in cranes sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Action Construction Equipment (ACE) Limited, India’s leading construction equipment manufacturer and the world’s largest pick-and-carry crane manufacturer, and KATO Works Co., Ltd., Japan’s globally recognised manufacturer of mobile cranes and construction machinery, announced ACE KATO Pvt. Ltd., their 50:50 joint venture company that will manufacture high-capacity cranes in India for domestic and global markets.

ACE KATO Pvt. Ltd has been incorporated to establish a dedicated manufacturing platform for truck cranes, crawler cranes and rough terrain cranes, catering to infrastructure, transportation, mining, ports, energy, metro rail, industrial and other heavy-duty applications.

The joint venture has established an 11-acre manufacturing facility in Haryana with a planned investment of approximately ₹200 crore. The investment will support manufacturing infrastructure,



advanced production systems, technology integration and product development, with additional investments to be made in phases to expand capacity and strengthen the company’s manufacturing capabilities.

Under the partnership, KATO will lead product engineering, design and technology, while ACE will be responsible for manufacturing, sourcing and localisation. The product roadmap will initially focus on the development and manufacturing of truck, crawler and rough-terrain cranes, followed by the phased introduction of more crane models.

The products will be manufactured in India for customers across domestic and

international markets, reinforcing the vision of ‘Made in India for the World’.

Commenting on the announcement, Sorab Agarwal, Executive Director, ACE Limited, said, “ACE KATO Pvt. Ltd. marks a defining milestone in ACE’s growth journey and reinforces our long-term commitment to strengthening India’s construction equipment manufacturing ecosystem.”

Commenting on the partnership, Tomoyasu Kato, Director, KATO Works Co., Ltd., said ACE has established itself as one of India’s most respected construction equipment manufacturers with strong manufacturing capabilities, a robust supplier ecosystem and an extensive market presence.

Dhairya retains top spot in ACAD QUAD school category

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Dhairya Pandey of Don Bosco Academy, Patna, has retained his top national rank for the second consecutive month in the School category of the online crossword challenge ACAD QUAD. The results for June of the year-long contest have been announced.

The remaining three categories – College, Senior, and Global – have seen new winners. Om Kumar Jha of NIT Manipur topped the College category, while R. Uma of Chennai secured first position in the Senior category. In the Global category, veteran Ramki Krishnan stood at the apex of the merit list.

The 2nd and 3rd positions across the four categories also featured several new winners, indicating increased participation from crossword enthusiasts. In the School category, Prashant Kumar Lency of Allen Career Institute, Kota, and Sahil Kumar of Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Residential School, Bharra, Begusarai, Bihar, won the 2nd and 3rd spots respectively.

In the College category, Shivam Kumar Jha of IIT Manipur and Pranav Kumar Jha of Muzaffarpur Institute of Technology secured 2nd and 3rd positions.

The Senior category saw Sree Prakash of Ernakulam and N. Rengaswamy of Chennai take 2nd and 3rd place.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (3.7.26)

3						7	1
7		9		2		4	
	2			8			
9			5				
	8	5	9	6	2	7	4
			4				2
		7				2	
		6		3		5	7
8	7						9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

SATURDAY | JULY 4, 2026

ACROSS

1 Is he less clever than Dick? (5)
6 Charges that bring tears? (5)
9 Huge lad, upset, took things lightly (7)
10 Demand 150, an excellent figure (5)
11 Those in the leaves of tangled vines? (5)
12 A number observed to be about five (5)
13 Various ways to get money? Nuts! (7)
15 Fade a lot, that is (3)
17 One or many men, maybe (4)
18 Agatha’s maybe robbed of an article, and shocked (6)
19 Fur bundled in bales (5)
20 Where the plug goes for a receiver (6)

DOWN

2 What can be used for lubricating? (6)
3 Affliction seeming trivial to a blockhead (6)
4 Plant that comes up in May (3)
5 Gapes at an unlucky goal conceded by Les (5)
6 It’s taken when Reg, being mad, is out to get even (7)
7 A large stream of uninvited entrants (4)
8 It can be bad for the elbow, sport (6)
12 It transpires in waste disposal (5)
13 When dogs go to earth, it means

trouble (5)
14 Because a music centre can be nice? (5)
15 One holding the boat up? (5)
16 Three can be useful in hospital (5)
18 False name as used in Dakar (5)
19 Marines in studios assembly (7)
21 His speech may seem endless! (6)
22 One may be so in order to listen (6)
23 Can you drink one twice? (6)
25 A critic of the legal system? (5)
26 A stable parent? (4)
28 Being low, it obviously isn’t a full moon (3)

BRIEFLY

Napoli hires former Milan coach Massimiliano Allegri



Serie A runner-up Napoli officially hired Massimiliano Allegri as coach on Friday. The news had been expected for weeks, since Antonio Conte confirmed he was leaving Napoli at the end of May and AC Milan fired Allegri following “an unequivocal failure” of a season. Allegri has signed a three-year contract at Napoli.

He steered Milan to the Serie A title in 2011 in his first stint in charge of the Rossoneri, and also led Juventus to five league titles and as many Italian Cup trophies.

The 58-year-old Allegri returned to Milan last year tasked with taking the Rossoneri back to the Champions League after the team finished eighth in Serie A the previous season. However, despite spending much of the campaign in the top two positions and fighting for the title, a run of only two wins in Milan's last eight matches dropped it to fifth on the last day of the season.

Napoli, which was plagued by injury problems all season, finished second. Conte had steered the team to the Serie A title the previous campaign, in his first year in charge.

Conte is one of the leading candidates to take over the Italian national team, for what would be his second stint as Azzurri coach. (AP)

Klopp signals willingness to take over as Germany coach



Julian Nagelsmann has resigned as Germany coach after his team failed to make the World Cup round of 16 for the third tournament running, and former Liverpool manager Jurgen Klopp is in line to take over.

Nagelsmann's departure, announced on Friday by the national soccer federation, comes four days after Paraguay stunned Germany on penalties in the round of 32 and follows talks with his bosses.

The federation said it planned to speak to Klopp and “he has already signaled his willingness in general to take on the role.”

It would be Klopp's first coaching job since leaving Liverpool in 2024.

Nagelsmann initially said he'd stay on with Germany on a contract which had another two years to run and reportedly made him among the highest-paid coaches at the World Cup. He faced mounting criticism over his tactics and team selection at the tournament.

Germany's defeat in the round of 32 followed group-stage losses at the 2018 World Cup in Russia and the 2022 World Cup in Qatar, when it was a 32-team tournament. It has not won a men's World Cup knockout game since beating Argentina in the 2014 final. (AP)

Spain goalkeeper Unai Simon sets record with 519 straight scoreless minutes in net

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Inglewood

Spain goalkeeper Unai Simon has the longest shutout streak in World Cup history, breaking a 36-year-old record while blanking Austria in a 3-0 victory Thursday for his fourth consecutive clean sheet in this World Cup.

Simon hasn't allowed a goal in 519 consecutive minutes across the past two World Cups. He broke the record set in 1990 by famed Italy goalkeeper Walter Zenga, who recorded 517 straight scoreless minutes and five consecutive clean sheets in his home World Cup.

The 29-year-old Athletic Bilbao mainstay isn't the most famous goalkeeper in this competition — or even on his own team — but Simon's outstanding play at the back of Spain's superb defence has launched him into the World Cup record books. Spain has yet to allow a goal at this World Cup, and its Basque backstop has only had to make four saves — none against Austria, which got none of its five shots on target. “I feel proud of him,” Spain coach Luis De La Fuente said. “I feel like he is a member of my family. I'm very happy for him.” Simon has been Spain's first choice in net for most of the past half-decade, keeping the job despite roster competition from David



Raya and Joan Garcia, the championship-winning goalkeepers in two of Europe's four biggest leagues.

Simon has spent his club career on smaller stages with Bilbao, which only reached the Champions League for the first time in his career last season.

Simon owes his international success to his stellar results and to his tight bond with De La Fuente, who has largely resisted calls to give more playing time to his goalkeeping options with more accomplished club careers.

Simon and De La Fuente have been bonded since 2015, when the coach and his 18-year-old keeper

won the European Under-19 championship in Greece. They stayed together in Spain's youth system and then reunited in early 2023, when De La Fuente took over the senior national team and promptly embarked on one of the most successful stretches in Spain's proud history.

Under De La Fuente, Spain has just one loss in 37 competitive matches, going unbeaten in its last 35 straight — a streak which includes a loss on penalties to Portugal in the 2025 Nations League.

Switzerland moves on to knockout stage

ANNE M PETERSON ■ Vancouver

Switzerland finally broke through with a win in a World Cup knockout match.

Breel Embolo and Dan Ndoye both scored and the Swiss advanced to the round of 16 at the World Cup with a 2-0 victory over Algeria on Thursday night.

Switzerland will play the winner of Friday's match between Colombia and Ghana in Kansas City, Missouri. The round-of-16 game is set for next Tuesday in Vancouver.

Switzerland had not won a knockout-round match since 1938 in France, but in 1954 the team won a playoff game to reach the quarterfinals.

Although the Swiss reached the round of 16 at the past three World Cups, there was a smaller field of 32 teams in each of those tournaments, and they could get no further.

“Today we write one page of history, but we want more, and we work for more,” Ndoye said.

“I think we show that we are a strong team, and now we need to



show it in the next game, and we hope again to the next game.”

Celebrating the victory, the Swiss players sat on the field as they were serenaded by their fans. As the song reached a crescendo, the players jumped up and danced.

Algeria was eliminated after returning to the World Cup for the

first time since 2014, when it advanced to the knockout round but fell to eventual champion Germany.

Algeria dominated the first 10 minutes before Johan Manzambi raced down the right side and crossed to Embolo for the tap-in. Embolo celebrated his 26th inter-

national goal with a knee slide.

“It was important to score at the right moment,” Swiss coach Murat Yakir said.

“It was a lucky punch, but then after that, I think that we were dominating on the pitch, and I'm really happy with the overall performance, because we played against very strong individual players.”

Less than a minute into the second half, Ndoye scored with a blast from the top of the box that diving Algeria goalkeeper Luca Zidane couldn't stop.

Fabian Rieder nearly got a third goal for Switzerland in the 81st minute but missed on the tap-in as the ball skirted across the face of Algeria's goal.

“I think the second goal was decisive. In the first half, we played a good match. We had several opportunities, and unfortunately we did not score,” Algeria head coach Vladimir Petkovic said. (AP)

Riyad Mahrez retires from Algeria national team

OWEN CAMEROS

■ Vancouver (British Columbia)

Riyad Mahrez, a five-time Premier League winner, announced his retirement from international soccer following Algeria's World Cup exit, a 2-0 defeat to Switzerland in the round of 32 on Thursday.

“There were good times and difficult times as well, of course. That's part of a career,” he said afterward. “But representing Algeria has been a dream of mine ever since I was young, to play for my country. It's been an immense honor and a great source of pride.”

He added: “It is the new generation's turn to play.”

As he walked off the field following the match, Mahrez gave a thumbs-up, then patted his heart and waved to the fans.



Mahrez, who plays for Al-Ahli in Saudi Arabia, has had an illustrious career at the club and international levels.

The 35-year-old forward retires with the second-most appearances for Algeria (119) and the second-most goals (40). Mahrez was a part of the Algerian team that won the 2019 Africa Cup of Nations. (AP)

Croatia vs Portugal: What happened in those final, chaotic minutes

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Toronto

In the 109th minute of a wild, pulsating, nerve-shredding World Cup match for the ages, referee Espen Eskas finally called time.

Portugal advanced to the round of 16 after a 2-1 win against Croatia at Toronto Stadium on Thursday.

That doesn't even begin to tell the story of the most dramatic of clashes that relentlessly swung back and forth and ended in the cruellest way for Croatia when Josko Gvardiol's would-be game-saving equaliser 13 minutes into added time was ruled out for offside after video review.

Croatia legend Luka Modric, age 40 and likely playing for the last time at a World



Cup, looked crestfallen at the final whistle.

The 41-year-old Cristiano Ronaldo lives to fight another day and couldn't hide his relief when just

moments earlier he stood helplessly on the sidelines in anguish, believing Portugal had blown it.

Here's how it all happened: **The First Goal in Added Time:** After 90 minutes of play, the electronic board signaled 10 minutes of added time, and it was difficult to imagine at that point just how much drama would be packed into the coming minutes.

Messi and Argentina await Cape Verde in the round of 32 at WC



ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Miami Gardens (Florida)

Argentina has the World Cup titles, arguably the best player of all-time in Lionel Messi, the rich history and a roster filled with stars.

Cape Verde has none of that. Soccer's version of David vs Goliath happens Friday night at Hard Rock Stadium, where defending World Cup champion Argentina faces a Cape Verde squad with absolutely no burden of expectations going into the round of 32 match.

“I believe we can do a great thing here,” Cape Verde backup defender Ianique dos Santos Tavares, who goes by the name Stopira, said through a translator on Thursday.

“And this is no exception. This match is no exception.”



A win by Cape Verde would be one of the most stunning upsets in soccer history, maybe even sports history.

Think of it on a “Miracle on Ice” scale from 1980, when the youthful U.S. hockey team stunned the supposedly unbeatable Soviet Union at the Lake Placid Olympics and went on to win the gold medal.

This would be a Miracle on Grass, without question.

Impossible for England to acclimate to altitude for Mexico match: Tuchel

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Atlanta

From the altitude of Mexico City to the memories of Diego Maradona's infamous “Hand of God” goal, England will have to contend with brutal conditions and the weight of history when it plays co-host Mexico at the World Cup on Sunday.

The Azteca Stadium — the site of the round of 16 game and the scene of Maradona's memorable goal against England in the 1986 World Cup quarterfinals — sits at more than 7,300 feet (2,200 meters) above sea level.

With little time to acclimate, conditions are against England's team and very much in favor of Mexico, which is undefeated in 10 World Cup games at its home stadium over three tournaments.

“My understanding is that we



cannot adapt to the altitude. That is just a huge advantage that Mexico will have,” England coach Thomas Tuchel said. “It just takes too much time.”

For elite athletes to perform at their peak at high altitude, a period of adaptation is required to reduce fatigue caused by lower atmospheric pressure and reduced oxygen availability.

Sports scientists generally recommend an extended acclimation period of at least two weeks, or the “fly-in, fly-out” method of arriving as close to game time as possible before acute symptoms set in.

Mikel's 2 goals send Spain past Austria 3-0, into round of 16 at World Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Inglewood

Mikel Oyarzabal scored two goals and Spain beat Austria 3-0 on Thursday for its first World Cup victory in a knockout match since winning the title in 2010.

Pedro Porro added a goal in the second half for Spain, which put on its most impressive performance of the tournament while dominating possession and demonstrating the offensive creativity across its vaunted lineup.

Spain also has yet to allow a goal at this year's World Cup. Unai Simon didn't have to make a save while keeping his fourth consecutive clean sheet, since Austria failed to get a shot on target.

“I'm happy to have helped the team for us to go through another round,” Oyarzabal said. “Now just rest and get ready for the next one. It was a complicated match. We knew that it was going to be difficult against a very physical team, but we had a very good day and played a good match.” La Roja will next face the winner of

Portugal's match against Croatia in Dallas on Monday in the round of 16.

The 18-year-old Barcelona sensation played his longest stretch of the tournament before coming off in the 85th minute, moments after Austria defender David Alaba deflected Yamal's hard shot off the goal line.

Spain got its marquee offense from Oyarzabal, the Real Sociedad captain who doubled his goal total at this year's World Cup by opening the scoring in the 36th minute and clinching the victory in the 89th. Marc Cucurella had assists on both of Oyarzabal's goals, demonstrating an excellent connection from the left side.

“The great teams step up when it's needed,” Spain coach Luis De La Fuente said. “We played a great match. We came close to perfection, but we must keep improving. There is always room for improvement, because every upcoming match will be very difficult.”

Goalkeeper Alexander Schlager made six saves in an outstanding performance for Austria, which reached the knockout rounds of its first World Cup since 1998 by squeaking out a late draw with an injury-time goal against Algeria. Coach Ralf Rangnick's team hasn't won a knockout match at the World Cup since 1954.





PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Manchester

With Vaibhav Sooryavanshi breathing down his neck, Sanju Samson will be under pressure to turn the frequent busts in his performance graph into consistent booms as India take on England in the second T20 International on Saturday.

The first game was abandoned after India posted a healthy 189 for 7 at the Chester-Le-Street in Durham, riding on half-centuries from Abhishek Sharma and skipper Shreyas Iyer.

However, the focus of attention during the next few games would be Sanju Samson and whether he can weather the Sooryavanshi storm that is building up on the sidelines.

In an alternate universe, three back-to-back match-winning knocks in India's T20 World Cup triumph would have given Kerala's most 'globally followed' sporting icon a



cushion for a year. But with Indian cricket discovering the generational talent of Sooryavanshi, Samson's margin for error has become minimal and the T20 World Cup halo alone can't save him.

With Abhishek Sharma smashing his way to 49 and 59 in two of the last three games, the pressure is entirely on Samson to get some runs under his belt.

In the opening game that was

washed out, Samson looked miserable scoring a single run off seven balls and not for once did it seem that he is trying to take the high-risk high-reward route.

The technical flaws in Samson's game don't inspire a lot of confidence when he plays on seaming tracks. Ireland's unheralded Jai Moondra, who actually hails from Rajasthan's Tonk, had exposed his frailties during successive games with deliveries

that moved off the surface. In case of Samson, the occasional high scores have always been flanked by a series of low returns on either side and that has been his biggest bane.

While the team management is firm on not pushing the 15-year-old Sooryavanshi but he possibly can't be kept cooling his heels if this continues for another couple of games.

However, it is not just Samson who is struggling in this batting order. The highly-talented Tilak Varma's held-back approach in the middle overs is also an issue.

Varma simply seems incapable of pushing the scoring rate once slow bowlers come into operation or seamers take pace off their deliveries.

In 12 T20I games in 2026, Varma has been able to hit only 12 sixes — which is one per game. And that statistic is poor for anyone who is seen as a finisher.

The bowling department is unlikely to feature any changes as Old Trafford track offers some grip and wrist spinners have had a good time at the venue.

Ireland to be more acceptable, says CI chief O'Donnell



G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Cricket Ireland president Bryan O'Donnell believes that the "impactful" T20 International series win over India recently will transform the national team into a "more acceptable opposition" globally, and open avenues for challenging assignments.

Ireland stunned India 2-0 recently at Belfast to register their first ever series win over the reigning T20 world champions in any format.

"Well, it's going to be fairly instantaneous because it is a

huge lift for our players and on that basis, they will probably become available in other areas of the game," O'Donnell told PTI.

"A huge amount of impact because it elevates the players. It lifts the potential performance of Irish cricket hugely," he added.

But the real impact of the win over a storied opponent, O'Donnell thought, will be the changed perception around Irish cricket. "I think we would be more acceptable as opposition than we may have been heretofore. So, you know, it is a moving elevation. (PTI)

Aakarshi, Tanya lose, Indian challenge ends in Canada Open



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Markham (Canada)

Tanya Hemnath and Aakarshi Kashyap lost their women's singles second round matches to draw curtains to the Indian challenge at the Canada Open here.

Tanya lost to third seed Riko Gunji of Japan 11-21 11-21 in 31 minutes while Aakarshi went down fighting to fourth seed Beiwen

Zhang of USA 22-20 17-21 17-21 in the second round match that lasted one hour and seven minutes.

Earlier, Tanya had prevailed 21-16 21-18 over USA's Disha Gupta in the opening round while Aakarshi saw off Anna Tatranova of France 21-14 21-12.

With the ouster of Tanya and Aakarshi, the Indian challenge ended at the Super 300 tournament.

Sciver-Brunt's stirring 75 leads England into Women's T20 WC final

FOSTER NIUMATA ■ London

Captain Nat Sciver-Brunt's awe-inspiring knock of 75 after an injury led England past South Africa and into the final of the Women's Twenty20 World Cup on Thursday.

Sciver-Brunt and former skipper Heather Knight rescued England from 23-3 with a 133-run partnership — the highest ever in a World Cup knockout match — to set South Africa a forbidding 170 target in The Oval semifinal.

South Africa, which chose to chase, had the life squeezed out of it and saw the writing on the wall as early as the 11th over after the great Marizanne Kapp was just the third out. By then the run rate required was already at 11 per over for the finalist in the previous two T20 World Cups. No 2-ranked England won by 40 runs and will face No 1 Australia in the final at sold-out Lord's on Sunday. It's the first time since 2010 that both teams in the final are unbeaten.

England put up 169-5 and South



Africa was shrunk to 129-8 in front of a women's T20 semifinal record attendance of 21,128.

Sciver-Brunt retired hurt against Ireland on June 16 due to tightness in the calf she tore in April. While missing England's last three group games, the captain threw everything into getting fit for the semi-

finals, including uncommon treatment using electromagnetic energy.

She replaced Sophie Dunkley, England's second highest run-scorer, and was called on just seven balls into the match as pacers Shabnim Ismail and Kapp

gave South Africa a dream start of three wickets inside four overs.

Ismail became the first woman to reach 50 career wickets in T20 World Cups and Kapp bowled Danni Wyatt-Hodge, the highest ever run-scorer in a single World Cup. But as Kapp and Ismail bowled out, their teammates were preyed on by Sciver-Brunt and Knight, who share more than 600 international caps. South Africa lost both of its reviews trying to get rid of Sciver-Brunt on 2 and 14. She reached her eighth fifty in a T20 World Cup, tying the record with New Zealand's Suzie Bates and Australia's Beth Mooney.

Knight followed. "I was nervous," Sciver-Brunt said. "The occasion gets quite big so that increases the nerves, and I have missed a few games. But as soon as the warmup started I managed to switch back on to game-time and just enjoyed myself out there. Heather and I... with our experience, we put our heads together and got the job done." (AP)

Indian junior women's hockey team to play 7 matches during UK exposure tour



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

A 24-member Indian Junior women's hockey team has flown to the United Kingdom for an exposure tour that will also feature matches against junior teams of

England and Scotland from July 5 to 14. The team departed from Kempegowda International Airport in Bengaluru on Thursday night.

Under new chief coach Tim White, the Indian junior women's team will play seven matches Scotland and

England as part of its preparations for key upcoming international tournaments, including the Junior Asia Cup.

The tour will commence with two matches against the Scotland senior women's team at the University of Edinburgh.

Stewart Cink, Charlie Wi share US Senior Open lead after opening 67s

JOE REEDYAP
■ Columbus (US)

Stewart Cink got off to a great start in a bid to win his third straight senior major.

Cink was the only player to make five birdies on the back nine at Scioto Country Club on Thursday, shooting a 3-under 67 for a share of the first-round lead in the US Senior Open with Charlie Wi.

Cink struggled on the front nine, shooting a 2-over 37, but found momentum once he made the turn.

"I've been off for a little while, and I



started like I've been off for a little while. I had to prove it to myself again that I could play decent golf a certain way," Cink said. "The back nine was really nice. I actually could have shot quite a bit lower on the back nine. I missed three very reasonably like inside -

right around 10 feet or less birdie putts."

The 53-year-old Cink has four wins in nine PGA Tour Champions starts this year, including the Senior PGA Championship and the Tradition.

The last player to win the Senior PGA, Tradition and US Senior Open in the same year was Jack Nicklaus in 1991. Scioto, the Donald Ross course hosting its third US Senior Open, is where Nicklaus learned to play the game.

Simon Griffiths, Freddie Jacobson and George McNeill were tied for third at 68. Defending champion Padraig Harrington was among a group of 10 players at 69. (AP)

Child before star: Balancing young talent



MR MISHRA ■ New Delhi

The scoreboards see runs. The selectors see talent. The public sees a phenomenon. But somewhere beneath the helmet and behind the growing celebrity is a 15-year-old still negotiating the uncertainties of adolescence.

As India celebrates the astonishing rise of batting prodigy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and eagerly awaits his debut, another conversation is quietly unfolding beyond his audacious strokeplay and remarkable poise.

It is a conversation that elite sport has wrestled with for decades: when extraordinary children enter an adult world, how does one ensure that exceptional talent does not come at the expense of a normal and ordinary childhood? There are no easy answers. If merit alone determines selection, Sooryavanshi deserves to be where he is. His recent performances in the IPL and other tournaments have made that case

emphatically.

Yet the arrangements surrounding his maiden senior tour are a reminder that cricket's newest sensation is still legally a child. The BCCI has allowed his parents to accompany him, while safeguarding regulations in England require separate changing-room arrangements for minors.

A boy considered mature enough to face international fast bowlers, but young enough to need the protection that childhood demands.

For leading sports psychologist Keerthana Swaminathan, that distinction should never be forgotten. "A 15-year-old is still a child before he's a star. But we end up interchanging that. We end up thinking he's a star first and then a child," Swaminathan told PTI. "We need to make sure we understand what we can expect from a child. Obviously, they have to have the scope to make mistakes." (PTI)

Gukesh rises to second spot in Grand Chess Tour Croatia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Zagreb (Croatia)

World champion D Gukesh made good use of his white pieces to beat Dutch Grandmaster Anish Giri in the final game of the day to rise to joint second spot after the second day of the Zagreb leg of the Grand Chess Tour here.

Iranian Grandmaster Firouzja Alireza is at the top by extending his lead by a huge three points. With 10 points in his kitty out of a possible 12, Alireza is far ahead of his rivals — Vincent Keymer of Germany, Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France, Deac Bogdan-Daniel of Romania and Gukesh, who all have identical seven points.

Another half point behind are India's R Praggnanandhaa, Giri and Nodirbek Abdusattorov of Uzbekistan while Croatia



Ivan Saric and Dutchman Jordan van Foreest are at the bottom of the table with just two points apiece.

Gukesh made most of his opportunities against Giri in a Ruy Lopez exchange variation.

For once, the Dutch Grandmaster of Nepalese origin

was seen lost from his prep book as Gukesh launched an attack against his king and never looked back.

We need to host more international tournaments to produce quality tennis players, says Uppal

SUMAN RAY ■ Gurgaon

Former Davis Cupper and Asian Games bronze medalist Vishal Uppal feels the need of hour for India is to host more international tennis tournaments to produce top-100 players from the country.

"If we look at other countries, they host 45-50 international tournaments a year to support their players. We do what, 10-12 maybe? So, the players are asking, where's the support? Why do we not have enough opportunities in this country," Uppal told PTI at his academy here on Friday.

"Again, please understand, the majority of players currently pursuing professional tennis are not from wealthy families. They lack the means to travel for 25-30 tournaments abroad. Now, unless we bring those opportunities to a wider pool of players, how will we help the raw talent to emerge? The people with the means don't have the hunger and the



people with the hunger don't have the means," he lamented.

He urged former players to help in bringing more international tournaments to India.

"What is stopping all the former players from getting together. If somebody hosts two international tourna-

ments in their city, someone else does too in theirs, you can do 10 or 15 tournaments like that. So you just take AITA's help to get those tournaments sanctioned, then you do it. I've hosted 10 women's world ranking events at this venue where we're sitting," Uppal said. "We need a lot of support. (PTI)